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— NEET (UG) 2026 —

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2 STUDENTS IN TOP 10

10 STUDENTS IN TOP 50

18 STUDENTS IN TOP 100

AIR



ARYAN GUPTA
App. No. 260410023990
(CIP)

AIR

9

GAURAV SINGH
App. No. 260410079810
(nPrep)

AIR

15

KRISH GUPTA
App. No. 260411104787
(nPrep)

AIR

16

KARTIK CHAUDHARY
App. No. 260410189559
(nPrep)

Narayana Students in Top 500 Open Category Ranks



AIR
22

HARSHIL GUPTA
App.No. 260410024522
nPrep



AIR
30

AKSHIT K. GAUR
App.No. 260410850821
nPrep



AIR
31

PRAKHAR BANSAL
App.No. 260410156444
nPrep



AIR
35

SABYASACHI LASKAR
App.No. 260410945197
nPrep



AIR
39

RANVEER KUMAR
App.No. 260410035204
nPrep



AIR
50

ARNAV JINDAL
App.No. 260410211081
nPrep



AIR
56

BHAVIKA GUPTA
App.No. 260410343476
nPrep



AIR
58

ANUSHKA CHOUDHARY
App.No. 260410021314
nPrep



AIR
71

BHAVYAA GUNWAL
App.No. 260410001881
Classroom Student



AIR
72

KRISH CHAUHAN
App.No. 260410298589
nPrep



AIR
76

ADITYA SHARMA
App.No. 260410342685
nPrep



AIR
78

THANTH K VIJAYBHAI
App.No. 260410543156
nPrep



AIR
79

DIVIT JAIN
App.No. 260410146253
nPrep



AIR
97

VINAYAK GARG
App.No. 260410140823
nPrep



AIR
125

SRINIVASA REDDY V
App.No. 260410240605
Classroom Student



AIR
142

CHAITHRA Y
App.No. 260410013102
Classroom Student



AIR
145

NIDHI YADAV
App.No. 260410255961
Classroom Student



AIR
150

N SAI SHRAYYA
App.No. 260411027019
Classroom Student



AIR
188

R JASWANTH RAM
App.No. 260410271452
Classroom Student



AIR
194

LOHITH KUMAR Y
App.No. 260410511141
Classroom Student



AIR
199

M B VARDHAN REDDY
App.No. 260410262142
Classroom Student



AIR
219

SHREYA KALE
App.No. 260410028123
Classroom Student



AIR
237

TANUSH V
App.No. 260410280979
Classroom Student



AIR
238

EASHAN JAGDEEP D
App.No. 260410100984
Classroom Student



AIR
258

NISHITA
App.No. 260410340507
Classroom Student



AIR
316

S ROHITH RAJU D
App.No. 260410723484
Classroom Student



AIR
347

VAIBHAV JINDAL
App.No. 260411216433
nPrep



AIR
357

SAISHA JAIN
App.No. 260410096340
Classroom Student



AIR
371

PRASHIL MAKWANA
App.No. 260410346182
Classroom Student



AIR
434

GURU BALA AKHIL A
App.No. 260411007179
Classroom Student



AIR
486

M YASHIKA
App.No. 260410226839
Classroom Student

All Category
All India Ranks
Below 10

7
RANKS

All Category
All India Ranks
Below 100

45
RANKS

All Category
All India Ranks
Below 1000

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A row of nine student portraits with their marks displayed in large 3D numbers. The marks are: 715, 705, 705, 705, 700, 700, 700, 700, 700.

STUDENT NAME	NEET-2025 MARKS	NEET-2026 MARKS	MARKS DIFF	STUDENT NAME	NEET-2025 MARKS	NEET-2026 MARKS	MARKS DIFF
SHRIPARNA KADAM	130	527	397	UTTAKALLA SIRISHA	242	521	279
BHUKYA VASINI	144	474	330	ABDULLA SHAIK	194	473	279
JALTHARU PRANITHA	145	473	328	BATTULA MADHURI CH	180	452	272
KANUMURI VARUN TEJA	143	465	322	LAKSHITHA SREE K	214	485	271
AKSHITHA	143	459	316	CHITTEM VENNELA	162	433	271
SINGANAMALA HARISH	113	422	309	G H RAMASWAMY NAI	165	435	270
SINDHU DORNADHULA	158	465	307	KOLEPAKA SMITHA	155	424	269
SOWMYA SREE PRATHAKOTA	120	417	297	SIVAKARTHIKEYAN I	222	487	265
YUVASVI V	134	426	292	MANNE DHANALAKSHMI	162	425	263
KARTHIK M	154	444	290	THARUNI NEELOTHPALA K	200	461	261
TANISHA MANDLOI	125	409	284	KUMMARI AKHILA	170	428	258

As per the information received at the time of publication

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CENTRAL FUNDS IN TELANGANA
Minister seeks inquiry into grant diversion
SOUTH » PAGE 8



SMILING AGAIN
Sindhu ends 19-month title drought
SPORT » PAGE 18



ESCALATING CONFLICT
Russian strikes kill 6 in Ukrainian cities
WORLD » PAGE 16



SAFETY NET
F&O sector needs strict entry barriers
Regulators must step in to arrest financial ruin
OPINION » PAGE 11



EXEMPTION FOR TRIBES
M.P. Cabinet gives nod to draft UCC Bill
NEWS » PAGE 14

NEARBY



Form high-level committees, CIC directs IITs

CHENNAI
Concerned over student suicides at IITs, the Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the institutes to set up high-level committees to recommend measures to prevent such deaths. » PAGE 6

Former Minister seeks proof for bribery claim

MADURAI
Former Minister P. Moorthy challenged Law Minister R. Nirmalkumar to furnish evidence to substantiate his allegation that bribes were collected in the Registration Department. » PAGE 6

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGES 2, 7 & 9

11 killed in J&K as heavy rain triggers flash floods

Nine deaths were reported from Poonch and two from Rajouri; initial assessment suggests that more than 100 houses and around two dozen school structures were damaged in the floods

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Eleven people were killed and 10 went missing in flash floods triggered by heavy rain in Poonch and Rajouri districts of Jammu and Kashmir on Sunday, officials said.

Nine deaths were reported from Poonch and two from Rajouri. Initial assessment suggested that more than 100 houses and around two dozen school structures were damaged in the floods.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah chaired a high-level review meeting at the Civil Secretariat in Jammu in the evening. He instructed all Deputy Commissioners and field agencies to closely monitor vulnerable areas, particularly those



Traces of ruin: Residents inspect vehicles damaged by flash floods and a landslide in Rajouri district of J&K on Sunday. AFP

prone to landslides, flash floods, and inundation, and ensure that rescue teams, machinery and essential services remain fully prepared to respond at short notice.

“Every possible effort should be made to trace and retrieve missing persons so that affected fami-

lies receive timely support... Besides, there should be expeditious restoration of roads, power supply, drinking water supply and communication links disrupted by heavy rain,” said Mr. Abdullah.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

Landslides in Nagaland town kill 8

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Landslides in at least 11 locations, triggered by heavy, incessant rainfall, killed eight people and injured 15 in Mon town in Nagaland on Sunday morning.

The town, which is the headquarters of Mon district bordering Myanmar, is about 300 km northeast of the State’s capital, Kohima. Mon Deputy Commissioner Wennyei Konyak said the landslides occurred around 6 a.m.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

HC rejects plea to transfer Wangchuk from Safdarjung

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after activist Sonam Wangchuk was moved from the site of his hunger strike to Safdarjung Hospital in New Delhi by the police, the Delhi High Court on Sunday refused any interim order in a petition seeking to transfer Mr. Wangchuk to a hospital of his choice. The petition filed by Gitanjali J. Angmo, wife of Mr. Wangchuk, who is on a hunger strike demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, alleged that the activist was confined to Safdarjung Hospital without his or his family’s consent.

Appearing for the petitioner in a special hearing, senior advocate Kapil Sibal submitted that Mr. Wangchuk was neither under detention nor accused of any offence and was therefore entitled to be treated at a hospital of his choice.



Gitanjali J. Angmo and CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

He submitted that the family of Mr. Wangchuk wished to shift him to Medanta Hospital in Gurugram, alleging that his own doctors had no access to him.

Justice Mini Pushkarna, hearing the petition, held that the decision to shift Mr. Wangchuk from Jantar Mantar to Safdarjung Hospital was taken in view of his deteriorating medical condition and could not be termed “arbitrary”.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

‘Wangchuk will end the strike if leaders meet him’

NEW DELHI

Activist Sonam Wangchuk will end his indefinite hunger strike if “political leaders meet him and provide an assurance that education accountability” will be the focus of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, his wife, Gitanjali J. Angmo, said on Sunday. “If there is no accountability, he will continue his fast,” she said. » PAGE 12

T.N. plans to cut VAT rate on aviation fuel

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government is planning to lower the State-level Value Added Tax on the Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF). The tax rate is 29% now. “We want to put it on a par with that of neighbouring States,” says an official. The actual rate will likely be made public shortly.

According to information disclosed by the Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas in the Lok Sabha four months ago, Andhra Pradesh charges 1%, Puducherry 14.5%, Telangana 16%, and Karnataka 18%. In Kerala, the sales tax rate is 5%, along with a cess of 1% on tax. Furthermore,

the four airports in the State – Thiruvananthapuram, Nedumbassery, Kannur, and Kozhikode – charge 1% tax and 1% cess.

The Tamil Nadu government’s plan is in response to the persistent request from the Union government for bringing down the rate, which is one of the factors that determine the operating cost of airlines.

About two months ago, Maharashtra and Delhi lowered the VAT rate on the ATF from 18% and 25% respectively to 7%. In Delhi, the reduction would be in force initially for six months. Maharashtra has set no such timeline.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

Final chapter



Moment of glory: Fireworks go off before the FIFA World Cup final match between Spain and Argentina in East Rutherford, near New York, on Sunday. REUTERS

U.S. launches strikes on Iran over killing of troops in Jordan

Associated Press
DUBAI

The United States launched more air strikes at Iran on Sunday in response to the killing of U.S. troops, and Iran fired missiles toward Jordan that risked widening the conflict into neighbouring Israel.

Step by step, the U.S. and Iran have returned closer to all-out war as last month’s interim deal meant to permanently end the fighting has crumbled and shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has largely stalled.

The U.S. military said the latest strikes targeted Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard to retaliate for Friday’s killing of troops in Jordan. The campaign, now in its second week, has seen the U.S. target bridges, water desalination plants and electrical facilities in Iran. Tehran has hit U.S.-allied countries throughout West Asia.

Kuwait, Jordan and Bahrain again activated their air defences for incoming Iranian drones and missiles. Kuwait said one of its power and water desalination plants was attacked for the second time in two days, causing fires.

Jordan’s military said it shot down several Iranian missiles. The country hosts major U.S. bases and relies on U.S. air-defence systems. The missiles did not cause casualties or damage, according to Jordan’s military.

Israel warned that missiles launched toward neighbouring Jordan could cause fire to spill over into Israeli territory for the first time in weeks.

Israel’s Defence Minister



A heavily damaged bridge which was hit by a U.S. strike in southern Iran on Saturday. AFP

Israel Katz said that his country would respond powerfully to any attack by Iran, after Israeli and Jordanian forces intercepted an Iranian missile launched towards the Jordanian city of Aqaba. “If Iran fires missiles at Israel, we will attack them with full force.”

The United States military’s Central Command said it hit “Iranian military coastal surveillance and air defence facilities, maritime capabilities and missile and drone storage sites”. It said the attack was designed to degrade Iran’s ability to control the strait and “swiftly punish Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps forces”.

Iran’s atomic energy agency said U.S. strikes targeted the construction site of a planned nuclear power plant in the southwest, state television reported.

Footage released by the U.S. military appeared to show strikes carried out by fighter jets and by Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from the sea. One target site appeared to be in a valley of a mountainous region. The Guard often has missile bases and other military equipment tucked into mountain ranges.

Opposition parties stage walkout from all-party meet

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

An invitation extended by Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju to a breakaway Trinamool Congress group prompted Opposition parties to stage a walkout from the all-party meeting held on Saturday, ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

They said Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla had not yet recognised the group’s claim that it had merged with the Tripura-based Nationalist Citizens Party of India.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 13

Cup of nostalgia: The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged takes a stroll down the lanes of history in Kolkata

Shreya Banerjee
KOLKATA

“That side,” said Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri awardee Usha Uthup, pointing towards the right corner of Trincas, a restaurant in Kolkata’s Park Street, “is where Sharmila Tagore and the Nawab of Pataudi would sit.”

Then she swept her hand across the room. “Farokh Engineer... the West Indies cricket team... Jyoti Basu... Uttam Kumar... Suchitra Sen...”

“I never had to go anywhere, the world came to me,” said the legendary singer as she remembered a particularly fond encounter with filmmaker Satyajit Ray at Park Street. The



Celebrated singer Usha Uthup in conversation with Shonali Muthalaly at the Trincas in Kolkata on Sunday. CHITROGRAPHER MEDIA

maestro visited Trincas often and had expressed his interest in making a film about a “Madras girl”. She paused before smiling. “It sounds like I’m dropping names. Which I am, actually.”

The audience erupted into peals of laughter.

Around them was the same dining room that had once hosted many of those famous names.

Music and memory

On Sunday, Trincas became both venue and subject as *The Hindu’s* Lit for Life Unplugged brought to-

gether Ms. Uthup and historian Anand Puri, third-generation custodian of the iconic Park Street restaurant, for *When Park Street Sings: A Conversation on Music, Memory & Kolkata*.

Moderated by *The Hindu’s* Associate Editor Shonali Muthalaly, the discussion moved between Ms.

Uthup’s five-decade musical journey and the history of Park Street, tracing how one restaurant became central to Kolkata’s nightlife.

Turning pages

The evening introduced Mr. Anand’s forthcoming book on revisiting the history of Kolkata in the last 100 years through the eyes of Trincas.

The event also turned the pages of Ms. Uthup’s memoir, *The Queen of Indian Pop: The Authorised Biography of Usha Uthup*, written by Vikas Kumar Jha and published by Penguin Random House.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

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Infosys

228
Students Placed in
Capgemini

205
Students Placed in
cognizant

119
Students Placed in
LTM

188
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91
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61
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INBRIEF



Quiz on military history organised for school students

A Military History and Awareness Quiz for school students was organised by Colours of Glory Foundation at the Russian Centre of Science and Culture in Chennai on Sunday. A total of 110 schools from the city participated. The quiz, conducted by war veteran Lt. Col. S.V. Sundar, aimed at fostering military heritage among school students. It was attended by nearly 220 students and over 100 parents and teachers. The Colours of Glory team was led by 1971 war veteran Captain D.P. Ramachandran. The chief guest of the event was Alexander Dodonov, Director of the Russian House in Chennai.

AISF takes out march in solidarity with Wangchuk

Students and activists under the aegis of All India Student's Federation (AISF) carried out a candlelight march in Chennai on Sunday, condemning the Centre's action to remove environmentalist and educationist Sonam Wangchuk from the protest site in Delhi. The Cockroach Janata Party has been protesting since June 6, demanding Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET paper leaks.

In 71% of T.N. classrooms, teachers do not check children's work: report

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In 71% of the classrooms in Tamil Nadu, teachers do not check written work or provide feedback to help children improve their learning, according to Teaching Learning Practices Survey (TLPS) 2025. The study, aimed at strengthening teaching and learning practices in basic literacy and numeracy, was anchored by the Language and Learning Foundation, supported by Tata Trusts, and implemented in the State by the Madhi Foundation and Educational Initiatives. The survey was conducted between November 2024 and March 2025 in nine States – Assam, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Meghalaya, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, and Uttar Pradesh – covering 21 districts and 1,050 classrooms. In Tamil Nadu, the report looks at the teaching-



In Tamil Nadu, the Teaching Learning Practices Survey 2025 was conducted in Krishnagiri, Villupuram, and Ramanathapuram.

learning practices of Classes I and II across Krishnagiri, Villupuram, and Ramanathapuram districts. It notes that the findings are based on the sampled classrooms and are not representative of the entire State. The report states that in 47% of the classrooms, teachers relied solely on choral response to check students' understanding. It also noted that print-rich materials were displayed in 77% of the classrooms, above the national average of 48%. Further, teachers' planned use of teaching-learning materials in mathematics was 61%, while children's was 77%.

"Almost 70% of the classrooms either skipped comprehension checks or relied on choral responses rather than individual checks to assess students' understanding," it said. The study recommended sustained focus beyond the early grades, though Tamil Nadu had made significant progress in prioritising basic literacy and numeracy through the *Ennum Ezhuthum* Mission.

Loco pilots want action dropped against motorman

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Loco pilots have urged Southern Railway to drop action against the motorman of an Electric Multiple Unit (EMU), who flagged a major signal failure and averted a disaster in Chennai Division on March 5. The case relates to an incident reported between Ambattur and Avadi stations, when Automatic Signal S192 displayed a 'Double Yellow' aspect, authorising an approaching EMU to proceed even though the line was occupied by two other trains. After spotting the trains stationed on the same track, motorman K. Karunakaran halted the EMU just short of the signal, preventing what could have been a major accident. He

photographed the scene on his mobile phone and alerted higher authorities. A multi-departmental committee that probed the safety lapse held the local technician responsible for the signal failure. The committee also holds Mr. Karunakaran "blameworthy" for not following the rules. Multiple signal failures The All India Loco Running Staff Association members have given a memorandum to the Divisional Railway Manager, Chennai, and other senior railway officials, saying the inquiry into the incident pointed to multiple failures in the signalling system. The signal failure was due to defective LED indication, unauthorised resetting of the system, and failure of diagnostic and alert

systems. It was also established that the system was not working in a fail-safe manner and that signal S192 displayed erratic and contradictory aspects. The root cause of the incident is purely system failure. The motorman of train no. 43221 faced a dynamic and abnormal situation. Initially, the signal showed caution aspect even though two trains were present in the section ahead. Recognising this abnormality, the motorman stopped the train. Subsequently, the signal changed to danger aspect, which indicated that it may have normalised. The signal was inconsistent. "Hence, the motorman had to take decisions based on the changing aspects and actual conditions observed on track," the association said.

The inquiry committee fixed the blame on the motorman citing provisions under Subsidiary Rules 3.74(i). However, this rule said that when a signal is flickering or showing irregular aspects, it must be treated as showing the most restrictive aspect. It also provides that when the signal becomes steady and remains so for 60 seconds, the loco pilot shall act according to the steady aspect. But in this case, the signal was not continuously defective. No clear instructions The motorman had acted in accordance with the rules. "It is also submitted that there are no clear instructions, either in rules or in training, regarding the procedure to be followed after restoring a sig-

nal from an abnormal or defective condition. While instructions exist for passing defective signals, there is no guidance on how to deal with situations where signals behave erratically," the memorandum said. In the absence of clear guidelines, fixing the blame on the motorman was not justified as he had displayed a high level of alertness. "He did not rely blindly on the signal, and exercised caution. Even after starting, he proceeded with restricted speed, keeping the situation under observation. Such conduct is in the interest of safety. If such actions are treated as blameworthy, it will discourage running staff from reporting signal abnormalities, and lead to loss of confidence in the signalling system," it said.

CMRL ropes in consultant to procure trains, upgrade stations in phase 1 network

It plans to buy 28 six-coach trains as commuters demand improved frequency during peak hours. AECOM India and Nippon Koei joint venture likely to be project management consultant: officials

TRACK TALES

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

To augment the capacity for the existing phase I network with additional trains and infrastructure, the Chennai Metro Rail has roped in a consultant as a first step. According to officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), AECOM India and Nippon Koei joint venture, the lowest bidder, is likely to serve as the project management consultant. Nearly 11 years after the launch of the Chennai Metro network, the city today has two operational corridors – Wimco Nagar to Chennai Airport and Chennai Central to St. Thomas Mount – covering a total of 54 km. As per the June data, the system records 3.2 lakh passengers a day.



CMRL has two operational corridors: Wimco Nagar to Chennai Airport and Chennai Central to St. Thomas Mount. FILE PHOTO

Though the present patronage is dismally low when compared to the projected ridership of 7.75 lakh passengers a day, commuters have been demanding that CMRL improve the frequency during peak hours, as the trains run packed during office hours. The peak hour congestion may worsen when the

118.9-km phase II network is opened to public. At present, the CMRL operates trains every three minutes from Washermanpet to Alandur, every six minutes from Wimco Nagar to Chennai Airport, and every 12 minutes from Chennai Central to Chennai Airport and Chennai Central to St. Thomas Mount.

Hence, the CMRL has planned to procure 28 six-coach trains (which is an upgrade from the existing four-coach trains) to improve the frequency, and modify infrastructure in the phase I stations to accommodate the additional trains.

'Bids floated'

"We have already floated the bids for train procurement, and the bids will open next month. This was done first as the trains will be delivered only in two years. To facilitate the train procurement and delivery process, and enhancing the stations to accommodate the six-coach trains, we needed a consultant on board first, as in the case of the phase I and phase II projects. The contract for this chosen consultant will be awarded shortly," an official said.

The work to modify the stations will be taken up later, he added.

Timings CHENNAI			
MONDAY, JUL. 20			
RISE	05:52	SET	18:39
RISE	11:09	SET	23:11
TUESDAY, JUL. 21			
RISE	05:52	SET	18:39
RISE	11:58	SET	23:49
WEDNESDAY, JUL. 22			
RISE	05:53	SET	18:39
RISE	12:48	SET	00:00

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	34	26
Chennai Airport	35	27
Chennai City	34	26

Chennai Airport Today 37°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy. There are chances of light rain and thundershowers.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow 38°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be slightly hot and uneasy. The night will be uneasy. Rain and thundershowers may occur.

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7.15 pm: V. AMIRTHALAKSHMI (Disciple of Dr.ThusharaSrinivasan)
Tomorrow 5.45 pm: SRIDEVI NRITHYALAYA 7.15 pm MALAVIKA&REKHAS
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Chaotic stretch: Traffic congestion is particularly severe on the road up to Thirumangalam junction. FILE PHOTO

Anna Nagar residents seek lasting solution to traffic congestion

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

Roads in Anna Nagar are becoming increasingly difficult to navigate, even on weekdays. Traffic congestion is particularly severe around St. Luke's Church, Blue Star signal, and the entire stretch up to the Thirumangalam junction. Even after 10 p.m. on weekends, traffic remains bumper to bumper, with motorists waiting several minutes to cross the junction.

Long-time residents blame the congestion on popular retail brands and commercial complexes that lack adequate parking facilities. They allege that security guards direct customers to park on the roadside, obstructing traffic. "Pedestrian plazas, too, are often occupied by two-wheelers belonging to shop staff and visitors from morning until around 9 p.m. on weekdays. And on weekends, the traffic worsens because several youngsters set up stalls along the road," S. Amarnath, a resident of Anna Nagar, said.

"Every time there is a complaint the government immediately removes all the small stalls (which are set up during weekends) and don't look at long-term solutions. The actual problems are created by the bigger shops, not the pushcarts," Hemalatha added. During weekends, many young entrepreneurs run stalls here. There are students, especially IAS aspirants, trying to earn money to pay their fees. Some are single mothers who sell

snacks or homemade food so they could educate their children. Residents agree that these weekend earnings are a lifeline to many and they don't deserve eviction. "The government should create an ecosystem where livelihoods and public convenience can coexist," they said. A regulated vending policy, designated spaces for weekend vendors, and organised paid parking (similar to Pondy Bazaar) could go a long way in easing congestion, they added.

A section of residents of Anna Nagar Fifth Avenue and adjoining streets has raised concern over worsening weekend traffic congestion. They attributed the traffic snarls to the growing number of pushcarts and street vendors occupying the roadsides. They also complained that food trucks and roadside stalls leave behind large quantities of garbage and plastic waste.

Despite the police deploying barricades, dangerous stunt riding by youngsters continues to be a growing concern. Residents suggested that the new government study the area's traffic and come out with a plan, and that vendors be given space for their businesses without disturbing the traffic.

A senior traffic police officer, who is in-charge of this zone, said: "We are constantly monitoring this area. Police have also removed vehicles parked in unauthorised zones from time to time. Barricades have also been put up to ensure there is no rash driving during nights."

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CHANGE OF NAME	THANKSGIVING

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INBRIEF



Brahma Gana Sabha's Aadi Natya Festival inaugurated

The Aadi Natya Festival, organised by Brahma Gana Sabha, was inaugurated in the city on Sunday. Industrialist Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti said the idea behind the festival was to provide opportunities to young dance exponents. “Children feel encouraged when they get to perform their *arangetram* in a sabha,” he added. Ravichandran S., secretary, Brahma Gana Sabha, said the festival was started nearly two decades ago. “December is considered the peak season for music, dance, and drama. But after that, it becomes dull. A season’s success depends on the flow of NRIs, which is at its peak during December, while the next best period is July-August,” he said. “Over time, there has been a good response to the festival from NRIs as well as residents of the city,” he added.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (July 20, Monday), the following articles are available:

- How the second phase of the Iran-U.S. war started and why it is raging [newsth.live/iranwar](#)
- What makes Skyroot’s Vikram-1 launch unique? [newsth.live/vikram1](#)

You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access these articles. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

OMR residents seek TNPCB probe into chemical odour

Residents say the odour begins around 9 p.m. and continues until daybreak; they urge the TNPCB to conduct surprise late-night inspections at industrial units in the Alathur pharmaceutical cluster

ECO WATCH
Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

Residents living along the Old Mahabalipuram Road (OMR) have urged the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) to investigate a recurring unpleasant odour that they say has been affecting neighbourhoods from Thiruporur to Semmancheri during the night. The Federation of OMR Residents Welfare Associations (FOMRRA) said residents have been experiencing a sharp sulphurous smell that begins around 9 p.m. and continues until daybreak. According to FOMRRA, residents have reported the issue from several apartment complexes and residential communities along the OMR stretch over the past few days. “About 10 days ago, some of us noticed an odour that smelled like a dead rat. It was different from the ammonia-like odour residents had experienced during earlier incidents. We initially checked our apartment ducts, thinking it was an isolated issue. But when we reached out to the wider community, residents from around 30 gated communities along OMR said they had been experiencing the same odour, mostly during the night,” said Harsha Koda, co-founder of FOMRRA. The residents’ body said that based on prevailing



Recurring issue: Residents say that the emissions are suspected to originate from the Alathur SIDCO Pharmaceutical Industrial Estate. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM (REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE)

wind patterns, the emissions are suspected to be originating from the Alathur SIDCO Pharmaceutical Industrial Estate, located about 10 to 15 km south of the affected areas. FOMRRA has urged the TNPCB to conduct surprise late-night inspections and continuous emission monitoring at industrial units in the Alathur pharmaceutical cluster during the hours when the odour is reportedly strongest. It has also

sought identification of the source of the emissions and strict action if any environmental violations are found. TNPCB officials could not be reached for a comment. Thiruporur MLA B. Vijayaraj said he will take note of the complaints and raise the issue with the TNPCB. He also said he would visit the pharmaceutical companies in the area.

History-sheeter shot by Thirumudivakkam police in escape bid

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A special police team shot and apprehended a 26-year-old history-sheeter who allegedly attacked a head constable while attempting to escape on Saturday.

A senior officer of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said the accused, Karuppu alias Tamilazhagu, was a resident of Eeswaran Kovil Street in Thirumudivakkam, and several criminal cases were registered against him, including 15 murder and attempt to murder cases.

Based on a tip off, a special team led by Thirumudivakkam police inspector Muthukumar apprehended him along with his associate Akash alias Surya, 24. Later, the police team based on their alleged confession, took Karuppu for recovering the weapons “they had hidden at a location near the Kavanur grounds” (near Kundrathur).

The police claimed that after reaching the spot, Karuppu took out a knife, and injured head constable Vijayakumar on his right elbow and attempted to escape. Immediately, the inspector took out his ser-



Karuppu

The inspector shot the accused Karuppu as he attempted to flee after attacking the head constable with a knife

vice revolver and shot the suspect on his right ankle and apprehended him.

Karuppu was taken to the Tambaram Government Hospital and was later shifted to Rajiv Gandhi Government Hospital for advanced treatment. The injured head constable received outpatient treatment.

The police said Karuppu, who is the brother-in-law of the notorious rowdy ‘Otteri’ Silambu, and Surya was involved in manufacturing country-made bombs.

PMK organises signature campaign urging State govt. to notify extent of Pallikaranai marshland

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss and party floor leader in the Assembly Sowmiya Anbumani on Sunday organised a signature campaign in Pondy Bazaar urging that the State government protect the Pallikaranai marshland and said the marshland should be officially notified by the State government.

Speaking during the campaign, Dr. Anbumani criticised former DMK minister P.K. Sekarbabu, who was in-charge of the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority, for not playing the crucial role of being the watchdog in the State for real estate development. He said, “CM Vijay must intervene directly in this matter. The marshland must be demarcated and

officially notified. Every day, 5,000 tonnes of garbage are dumped and burnt in the marshland. Construction companies are instigating people living there. They make them claim that they have no land titles and that they are middle-class families, using them as part of a conspiracy. There is no need for protests over this issue. Once the marshland is properly demarcated and offi-

cially notified, it cannot be encroached upon.”

‘Water crisis’ Ms. Sowmiya said, “The reason this issue has become so important today is the water crisis. Chennai is a huge city with a population of nearly ten million people. We cannot drink the water of the Cooum River. Despite having three rivers, Chennai has no usable water. There are no

lakes or ponds left in Chennai. The government itself has built residential colonies on lands where lakes and ponds once existed. The marshland is the sponge that absorbs rainwater. Only if the marshland exists will groundwater be available. If water is to flow when we open our taps, the marshland must be protected. Otherwise, south Chennai will become barren.”

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MTC bus overturns in Sholinganallur, commuters escape with minor injuries

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Several commuters onboard a Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) bus escaped with minor injuries after the vehicle overturned on the Sholinganallur Main Road on Sunday.

The Pallikaranai Traffic Investigation police registered a case, and are probing the incident.

A senior officer of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said the bus from Tambaram West to Adyar (route no. 99) had more than 20 passengers onboard, and was proceeding on the Sholinganallur Main Road via Perumbakkam when the incident occurred.

As the bus neared a small stretch, designated as a one-way road, where Metro Rail work was under way, a speeding lorry ap-



Close call: The MTC bus being recovered from a ditch in the Pallikaranai marshland after it overturned on Sunday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

proached it from the opposite direction.

To avoid crashing into the barricade, the bus driver applied a sudden brake, due to which the vehicle

overturned and fell into a ditch in the Pallikaranai marshland. A few passengers, who sustained minor injuries, were admitted to the Medavakkam Govern-

ment Hospital. Fire and Rescue Services personnel from the Medavakkam station were engaged in recovering the bus from the ditch.

Woman killed in road accident

CHENNAI: A 24-year-old woman was killed after being run over by a car in K.K. Nagar on Sunday. The Pondy Bazaar Traffic police have arrested the car driver Senthil Kumar, 52.

The traffic police said that the deceased, Hemalatha, hit a motorcycle as

she was proceeding on a two-wheeler on Anna Main Road. In the impact both Hemalatha and the other motorist fell. Before Hemalatha could get up, a car ran over her, killing her on the spot. The other motorist escaped with minor injuries.

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Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of Work	Date of Tender	
			Closing	Opening
1	202647 2212299	Interior Design of Vande Bharat Sleeper Trainset	07.08.2026 15.00 Hrs	07.08.2026 After 15.00 Hrs.

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY
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Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of Work	Date of Tender	
			Closing	Opening
1	202647 2212297	Migration of the ICF PLM System to Teamcenter	07.08.2026 15.00 Hrs	07.08.2026 After 15.00 Hrs.

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY
Chennai - 600 038

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Open Tender No.	Short Description of the lte	Tender Value (Rs.)	Period
202649 9212295	“Service contract for Fire Fighting in ICF	Rs. 2,36,00,281/-	731 Working Days

Date of Tender	
Closing	Opening
11.08.2026 at 14.45 hrs	11.08.2026 at 15.00 hrs.

Hindi Version of the above advertisement is available in [https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in](#)
Chief Safety Officer/Fur

National Highways Authority of India
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The applicant is required to ensure submission of online application as per the procedure indicated in the detailed advertisement, available on NHAI website ([https://www.nhai.gov.in](#)), by **19.08.2026 (upto 06:00 PM)**.
3. आयु सीमा, योग्यता मानदंड, अन्य शर्तों और से संबंधित विस्तृत विवरण भारतीकरण की वेबसाइट पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
Details regarding age limit, eligibility criteria, other conditions etc. may be accessed on NHAI website.
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INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY
Chennai - 600 038

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Open Tender No.	Short Description of the Item	Tender Value (Rs.)	Period
202649 9212296	Service contract for Hiring of 3 Ton & 5 Ton Fork Lift Trucks with Driver & Fuel along with Associated staff for Movement of Coaches in shop 30 at Furnishing Division	Rs. 6,05,19,986/-	580 Working Days

Date of Tender	
Closing	Opening
11.08.2026 at 14.45 hrs	11.08.2026 at 15.00 hrs.

Hindi Version of the above advertisement is available in [https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in](#)
Chief Safety Officer/Fur

From Page One

T.N. plans to cut VAT rate on aviation fuel

The reduction is seen as a relief to the aviation sector grappling with airspace closures, uncertain operations, and a sharp increase in ATF prices after the tension mounted in West Asia. But the Union government has been urging Tamil Nadu and other States to cut the rate for tax rationalisation. The ATF accounts for a major chunk of airlines’ operating cost. It is, in turn, determined by several factors like the VAT. Aircraft fuel and oil expenses account for 40%-45% of the total operating expenses of the scheduled Indian operators.

In March 2025, Minister for Civil Aviation Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu told Parliament, “Taking cognisance of the high VAT on ATF levied by the States and the Union Territories, the issue was taken up with them. As a result, the VAT has been reduced by 19 States and the Union Territories...” In February 2023, his predecessor, Jyotiraditya M. Scindia, while participating at an event in Chennai, made an open appeal to the State government to decrease the VAT as Tamil Nadu was one of the seven States with 20%-30% VAT on the ATF.

INBRIEF



Vijay congratulates National Film Award winners from T.N.

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has congratulated artistes from the Tamil film industry for winning 10 National Film Awards across various categories. The winners of the 72nd National Film Awards, recognising films released in 2024, were announced on Saturday, with artistes from the Tamil film industry winning 10 awards across various categories. In a statement, Mr. Vijay congratulated the award winners and said it was a proud moment for Tamil Nadu.

‘Don’t make Vande Mataram’s full version the national song’

The State Platform for Common School System-Tamil Nadu (SPCSS-TN) appealed to Parliamentarians to oppose the introduction of The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 and protect the Constitution of India. The Bill is to be introduced in the Rajya Sabha on July 20 by the Centre. The Bill is a legislative measure to adopt the full version of *Vande Mataram*, as found in the novel *Anandamath*, as the national song of India. In a statement, the committee said the song in the novel depicts a deity of a particular faith as this nation. “Nowhere in the song can we find the name of this nation as stated in Article 1 of the Constitution of India. India or Bharat is the name of our motherland, but the song proposed in the Bill mentions neither of the two,” said P.B. Prince Gajendra Babu, SPCSS-TN general secretary.

Form high-level committees for preventing student deaths by suicide, CIC directs IITs

It says information on panels must be proactively disclosed on the institutes’ official websites. The direction came while disposing of appeals filed by an IIT-Kanpur alumnus, who is the founder of a non-governmental organisation engaged in student rehabilitation and mental health counselling

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Expressing concern over recurring student suicides across Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), the Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the institutions to constitute high-level committees to recommend measures for preventing such deaths and mitigating the factors that contribute to them.

The direction came while disposing of appeals filed by Dheeraj Kumar Singh, an alumnus of IIT-Kanpur and founder of a non-governmental organisation (NGO) engaged in student rehabilitation and mental health counselling.

Mr. Singh, under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, had sought details regarding the students, research scholars, and staff who ended their lives at IIT-Madras, IIT-Kanpur, IIT-Goa, and IIT-Jodhpur since January 1, 2005.

He wanted information including age, gender, caste/category, academic programme, native State, date of suicide, and whether the death occurred on



The petitioner, under the RTI Act, had sought details regarding the students, research scholars, and staff who ended their lives at IIT-Madras, IIT-Kanpur, IIT-Goa, and IIT-Jodhpur since January 1, 2005.

the campus. Stating that the details were required for academic research, he said the names of the deceased could be withheld if necessary.

Details withheld

In response, IIT-Madras informed him that seven suicides had been reported between 2019 and June 26, 2025, but declined to disclose personal details, such as age and caste, citing the exemption under Section 8(1)(j) of the Act relating to personal information. The First Appellate Authority upheld the decision. IIT-Kanpur informed

the applicant that 17 suicides had been reported between 2005 and 2025. The data furnished by the institute showed that at least one suicide was reported every year during the period, with three cases recorded in 2024. However, it too withheld the personal particulars of the deceased under Section 8(1)(j).

Similarly, IIT-Goa denied disclosure of personal information, describing it as third-party information exempt from disclosure, while IIT-Jodhpur informed the applicant that no such cases had been re-

ported. Aggrieved over the denial of complete infor-

mation, Mr. Singh moved an appeal before the CIC. He contended that the information he had called for was essential to analyse the root causes of student suicides across factors such as age, gender, and social category, and would help strengthen his organisation’s mental health counselling programmes for students facing academic and personal stress.

The information was crucial to strengthen the NGO’s programmes for uplift and counselling of students. The IITs, howev-

Former DMK Minister challenges Nirmalkumar to substantiate bribery allegations against him

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Former Minister for Registration P. Moorthy of the DMK on Sunday challenged Law Minister R. Nirmalkumar to furnish evidence to substantiate his allegations that bribes were collected in the Registration Department during the previous DMK regime.

“The Minister should provide details of the Sub-Registrar offices, survey numbers, and registration documents for which commission was allegedly collected on my behalf,” Mr. Moorthy told reporters in Madurai.

He was responding to repeated allegations by Mr.

Nirmalkumar that, while serving as Registration Minister, Mr. Moorthy had stationed his associates at every registration office across the State to collect a 20% commission on every property registration during the DMK regime.

“I held meetings only with the senior-most officials of the Registration Department as Minister and never spoke to any of the 589 Sub-Registrars in the State. The Government can very well conduct an inquiry with the officials,” Mr. Moorthy said.

He claimed that revenue generated by the Registration Department had increased from ₹10,000 crore in 2021 to ₹25,000



P. Moorthy

crore in 2026 under the DMK regime.

Referring to the recent alleged illegal transfer of a large parcel of land belonging to Sri Dhandayuthapani Swamy Temple in Palani

to private individuals, Mr. Moorthy questioned how the transaction had been registered when the Registration Department had special markings for HR and CE temple lands that prohibited such transactions.

Mr. Moorthy said Mr. Nirmalkumar, who also holds the Electricity portfolio, should focus on ensuring uninterrupted power supply in the coming days rather than making what he described as baseless allegations against him.

DVAC seizures

Referring to Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay repeatedly claiming there was no brib-

ery in government offices after the TVK assumed power, Mr. Moorthy said surprise inspections by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) had led to the seizure of bribe money amounting to several lakhs of rupees from various government offices, contradicting the government’s claim.

He also referred to corruption allegations raised by a TVK woman functionary over the appointment of a Government Pleader.

“After promising to increase the free power supply from 100 units to 200 units, the TVK government has only increased power tariffs,” he said.

Farmers ask DMK to drop demand for Mekedatu tribunal

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUCHI

P.R. Pandian, president of the Coordination Committee of All Farmers Associations of Tamil Nadu, on Sunday urged the DMK to drop its demand for the formation of a tribunal on Mekedatu, stating that it would jeopardise the livelihood of Tamil Nadu farmers. Speaking to reporters here, he said the recent resolution adopted in the Assembly, which incorporated a key amendment moved by Leader of the Opposition Udayanidhi Stalin seeking the formation of a new tribunal over the proposal to build a balancing reservoir at Mekedatu, was against the law and farmers’ interests.

The coordination committee, Mr. Pandian said, had welcomed the DMK’s move to bring an adjournment motion on the Mekedatu issue in the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha. However, farmers were against the move demanding the formation of a tribunal on Mekedatu. If the DMK went ahead with this, it would go against the Supreme Court direction that no reservoir or new dams should be built without the permission of lower riparian States. It was contrary to the final verdict of the Cauvery Tribunal as well. Hence, the DMK should refrain from its demand for the formation of Mekedatu tribunal, he added.

Correction

In the report titled “Dr. Ambedkar Law University cancels affiliation for three private colleges” that appeared in the July 19 edition, it should read “Sources in the TNDALU said that Thulasi Women’s Law College had a change of ownership...” and not as stated. The error is regretted.

Goddess Saraswati without veena: glimpses of an early iconography

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

At the Arthamandapam of the Gangaikondacholapuram Temple, just outside the sanctum sanctorum, stands an unusual image of Goddess Saraswati – one that is notably without the veena, the musical instrument now regarded as her defining attribute.

Seated in *padmasana* with four arms, the deity is identified as Saraswati by the *suvasi* (manuscript) she holds in one hand and the *akka mala* (rudraksha rosary) in another. The remaining two hands hold an *ankusha* (goad) and a *pasha* (noose), iconographic features rarely associated with conventional representations of the Goddess.

“She is one of the war trophies brought to Tamil Nadu following the Cholas’ northern campaign. The image originally belonged to the Pala dynasty,” according to R. Komagan, chairman of the Gangaikondacholapuram Development Council Trust.

Historian Kudavasal Balasubramanian, in his book

Rajendra Cholan - Victories, Capital and Temples, also identifies the sculpture as belonging to the artistic tradition of North India. “She wears a crown, *kundalams* in her ears, and ornaments on her neck, chest, shoulders, arms, and legs. She is entirely different from the Saraswati images sculpted in Tamil Nadu and represents the north Indian style. It could be one of the war trophies brought by the Chola kings,” he writes.

A Chola masterpiece

The Pala Saraswati is not the only veena-less depiction of the Goddess at Gangaikondacholapuram. The temple is also home to the celebrated Gnanasaraswati, one of the masterpieces of Chola sculpture, located on the walls near the steps leading to the Arthamandapam. Like the Pala image, this sculpture too portrays the Goddess without a veena, suggesting that the instrument became a standard attribute of Saraswati only in a later phase of iconographic evolution.

According to Lalitharam of Visamayam, an organi-



Different forms: Idols of Saraswati in the inner prakarams of the Brahadeeshwarar Temple at Gangaikondacholapuram and the Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram. R. VENGADESH



sation that creates replicas of outstanding Pallava and Chola sculptures, the Chola-era Gnanasaraswati is seated on a lotus with her hair arranged in an elaborate *jata makuta*. She is richly adorned with necklaces, shoulder ornaments, bangles, and *makara kundalams*. Instead of a veena, she holds a *suvasi* in one hand and an *akka mala* in another, underscoring her identity as the embodiment of learning and spiritual wisdom.

Of the remaining two hands, one carries a *kundigai* (*kamandalu*), while the other is shown in *tarjani mudra* – a rare and strik-

ing gesture in Saraswati iconography.

While Mr. Komagan believes the Pala Saraswati may have inspired the Chola sculptors who created the Gnanasaraswati, there is no epigraphic or archaeological evidence to conclusively establish such a connection. The absence of the veena, however, is not unique to Gangaikondacholapuram.

Dr. R. Kalaikovan, founder of the Dr. Rajamanickanar Centre for Historical Research, points out that Pallava-period and Chola-period Saraswati sculptures also lack the instrument. “The Saraswati sta-

tues in the Kailasanathar Temple are without a veena. One deity has a *suvasi* and *akka mala* in two hands while the other two hands are damaged. Another sculpture carries a *kundigai* or *kamandalu*,” he said.

He explained that the *akka mala* and *kundigai* were traditionally associated with Brahma, the creator God, and Saraswati, revered as his consort, was therefore portrayed with these attributes.

“Even the Saraswati sculptures at the Brihadisvara Temple and Sadaimudinathar Temple at Tiruvallanchuzhi are without a veena. The Gnanasaraswati at Gangaikondacholapuram is especially significant because of the *tarjani mudra*, a threatening gesture that is highly uncommon in depictions of Saraswati,” he said.

The Saraswati image at the Brihadisvara Temple has suffered extensive damage to its right hand, making it impossible to determine what attribute it originally held.

Another important example is found at the Aira-

vatesvara Temple, where Saraswati closely resembles the Gangaikondacholapuram sculpture. The Darasuram and Gangaikondacholapuram images depict the Goddess with an uncovered torso, whereas the Thanjavur sculpture shows her with a partially-covered chest.

Hoysala temples

Although it is difficult to determine exactly when the veena became Saraswati’s defining attribute, sculptures from Hoysala-period temples frequently portray the Goddess holding the instrument, often in graceful dancing postures. Sanskrit literature contains references to Saraswati with a veena. Saraswati and veena are inseparable in Ravi Varma’s paintings.

Interestingly, the presiding deity at the Koothanur Saraswathi Temple – one of the few temples in India dedicated exclusively to Saraswati – is also without the instrument. According to temple inscriptions, the shrine was renovated during the reign of Kulothunga Chola II and is traditionally

associated with the Tamil poet Ottakoothar, after whom the village derives its name.

“The presiding deity is seated on a lotus and carries a *mudra*, a *suvasi*, an *akka mala*, and a *kundigai*. The Saraswati depicted on many temple walls with a veena represents the *Sangeetha Swaroopa* form, which belongs to a later iconographic tradition,” said the temple priest Sundar Gurukkal.

Taken together, the sculptures at Kancheepuram, Thanjavur, Gangaikondacholapuram, Darasuram, Tiruvallanchuzhi, and Koothanur point to an important evolution in the iconography of Saraswati. Earlier representations in south India consistently emphasised her role as the Goddess of knowledge, learning, and spiritual wisdom through attributes such as the manuscript, rosary, and *kamandala*. The veena, today regarded as inseparable from Saraswati’s identity, appears to have emerged as her dominant symbol only in the later depictions of the Goddess.

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Where every child's future begins

The Vaazh Foundation Launches Educational Assistance Scheme 2026-27

Initiative to support talented and deserving students from Underprivileged backgrounds to pursue higher education

ADVERTISEMENT



Chennai, July 12, 2026: The inaugural function of the "Vaazh Educational Assistance Scheme 2026-27" – a programme that identifies talented students unable to pursue higher education owing to financial hardship, loss of parental support, and similar circumstances, and extends financial assistance to them – was held today at the Vaazh Foundation Charitable Trust office in Anna Nagar, Chennai.

The Vaazh Foundation Charitable Trust (VFCT), headquartered in Chennai with a branch office at Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. The Trust has been rendering continuous service across Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and Uttar Pradesh through Skill Development Programmes, Educational Assistance, Scholarships, Community Outreach, Food Donation, and free medical services.

The function was presided over by **Mrs. Susheela Ramachandran, Managing Trustee of AMET University. Mrs. Ramya Ramachandren - Vice Chairperson, Saraswathi Group of Institutions and Founder & Managing Trustee, VFCT, SACT** distributed the educational assistance to the underprivileged and

unsupported 26 students. the public and beneficiaries participated in the event in large numbers.

Participants remarked that the occasion was more than a ceremony- it was a historic moment in which the founders long cherished dream came true.



One student's education is a family's future and a community's progress. This scheme is being implemented with the firm conviction that no deserving student should be denied the dignity of higher education for economic reasons.

-Mrs. Ramya Ramachandren
Founder & Managing Trustee, VFCT



For further information:



Vaazh Foundation Charitable Trust (VFCT)

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IUML tells its Ministers to be cautious about policies

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

The Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leadership has asked its Ministers in the United Democratic Front (UDF) government in Kerala to tread carefully while supporting coalition policies, amid criticism over the party's positions on issues such as Waqf, PM SHRI and the government's move to reduce taxes on low-alcohol beverages.

Facing pressure from various quarters over decisions perceived as a shift from its earlier positions, the IUML wants its Ministers to back UDF policies while ensuring that their statements and actions do not create confusion over the party's stand.

Waqf Board issue

The Waqf Board issue has emerged as the biggest challenge for the party. The government's submission before the Kerala High Court that it would reconstitute the State Waqf Board in accordance with the Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025, has invited criticism from Muslim organisations.

Waqf Minister N. Sam-sudheen's statement that the government would abide by the law has also come under scrutiny.

The High Court had frozen the functioning of the existing board, citing the absence of a Shia member and two non-Muslim members as required under the amended law. The board has challenged the order in the Supreme Court.

Minister claims diversion of Central funds in Telangana

Bandi Sanjay Kumar alleges developmental funds are being utilised for staff salaries, electricity bills, and other administrative expenditures; urges Centre to put in strict monitoring mechanism

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar on Sunday urged Union Minister for Panchayati Raj Rajiv Ranjan Singh to conduct a special inquiry into the utilisation of 15th Finance Commission grants in Telangana, alleging that funds were being diverted for purposes other than those permitted under the guidelines.

In a communication released to the media, Mr. Sanjay Kumar has sought immediate directions to the State government to ensure that funds earmarked for village development are not used for un-



The Congress government must explain the alleged diversion of funds, the Minister said in the letter. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

authorised purposes.

The Minister claimed that the funds were being utilised for staff salaries, electricity bills, routine maintenance and other administrative expenditures instead of developmental work.

He further alleged that gram panchayat sarpanches had expressed serious concern over being pressured to use the funds for such non-permissible purposes.

The Union government should put in place a strict

monitoring mechanism to ensure that funds released to gram panchayats are utilised exclusively for intended developmental works, he said.

Mr. Sanjay Kumar said a total of ₹2,293.74 crore had been released in phases and credited to the State Treasury so far, while another ₹729.41 crore remained due for release.

The Congress government should be asked to explain the alleged diversion of funds, Mr. Sanjay Kumar said in the letter.

He also urged the Union government to direct the State government to initiate disciplinary and legal action against officials responsible for diverting the funds.

YSRCP decries 'neglect' of Handri-Neeva canal project; TDP terms charge baseless

The Hindu Bureau
ANANTAPUR

The Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) leaders in Andhra Pradesh on Sunday inspected the Handri-Neeva canal system from Cholasamudram to Narayanapuram, and demanded expansion of its capacity to 11,500 cusecs.

The party alleged that the NDA government weakened one of Rayalasee-

ma's critical irrigation projects through poor execution and policy reversals.

As part of their "Chalo Cholasamudram" protest to highlight the alleged neglect, the leaders visited the canal, and said its lining and expansion works were of substandard quality. They alleged large-scale irregularities in works costing ₹3,000 crore, and asserted that had the works been executed properly,

Anantapur district would have received up to 80 tmc ft of water. The NDA government had cancelled the orders issued during the YSRCP term and reduced the canal's capacity to 3,850 cusecs, undermining the irrigation needs of Rayalaseema, they said.

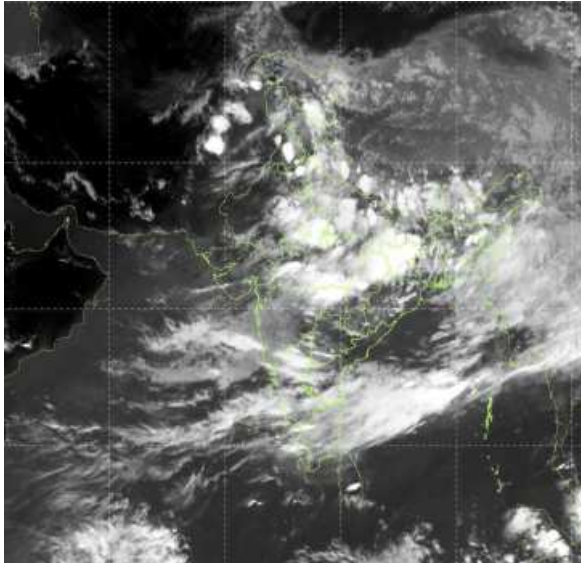
The YSRCP leaders alleged that hundreds of crores of rupees have been siphoned off. They also criticised Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu for

halting the Rayalaseema Lift Irrigation project.

Meanwhile, Finance Minister and Telugu Desam Party leader Payyavula Keshav alleged the YSRCP, which lost public support, was struggling for relevance and levelling baseless allegations on the Handri-Neeva works. He said the YSRCP, which had neglected the project during its term, was now staging a drama to mislead the public.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Uttarakhand, Assam, Meghalaya, Bihar, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Punjab, sub-Himalayan West Bengal, Sikkim and Uttar Pradesh.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		31.4	26.2	Kurnool		4.9	33.0
Ahmedabad		1.0	36.4	Lucknow		—	29.0
Aizawl		1.4	28.1	Madurai		—	40.0
Bengaluru		15.0	23.8	Mangaluru		8.7	28.6
Bhopal		—	33.1	Mumbai		14.4	29.8
Bhubaneswar		0.6	34.8	Mysuru		—	30.2
Chandigarh		6.4	36.0	New Delhi		—	37.2
Chennai		0.6	34.3	Patna		—	32.2
Coimbatore		—	33.0	Port Blair		31.4	25.9
Dehradun		38.4	30.1	Prayagraj		1.6	34.6
Gangtok		24.0	21.6	Puducherry		0.2	35.1
Goa		2.0	32.8	Pune		4.5	38.1
Guwahati		0.8	30.5	Raipur		4.0	29.8
Hubballi		—	28.0	Ranchi		9.0	30.4
Hyderabad		—	33.0	Shillong		15.5	24.4
Imphal		18.2	23.3	Shimla		3.9	22.4
Jaipur		—	36.7	Srinagar		4.0	29.2
Kochi		18.8	29.9	Thiruvananthapuram		0.5	31.0
Kohima		—	—	Tiruchirappalli		—	38.5
Kolkata		4.8	31.0	Vijayawada		1.1	37.4
Kozhikode		4.2	30.9	Visakhapatnam		—	34.5

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE
Ahmedabad		5	135	14	30	■
Bengaluru		3	110	352	11	■
Chennai		8	9	296	22	■
Delhi		13	16	243	129	■
Hyderabad		3	4	228	9	■
Kolkata		5	7	300	16	■
Lucknow		9	17	370	51	■
Mumbai		5	8	252	11	■
Pune		4	7	142	4	■
Visakhapatnam		31	17	343	21	■

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

INBRIEF



Omicron RF.5 detected in A.P. as COVID-19 cases rise to 19

Nearly three weeks after the first COVID-19 case was reported in Andhra Pradesh, the State government has said that genome sequencing has identified the Omicron RF.5 sublineage in samples tested at the National Institute of Virology (NIV), Pune. Based on the scientific evidence available so far, the variant does not appear to be more dangerous than other Omicron sublineages, Director of Medical Education A. Vishnu Vardhan said. The State has reported 19 COVID-19 cases between June 26 and July 19, including three on Sunday.

Karnataka now has highest number of medical seats

The National Medical Commission has sanctioned two private medical colleges for Karnataka for 2026-2027 and approved an enhancement of a total of 1,300 seats. It has approved Alva's Institute of Medical Sciences and Research Centre in Dakshina Kannada and Chettinad Institute of Medical Education and Research in Kolar. A total of 15,395 medical seats are available in 75 medical colleges in the State. Karnataka has now emerged as the State with the highest number of medical seats in the country.

'Natural accidental causes' led to eight elephant deaths: SIT

Eight elephants, which were found dead in a river flowing through the Malayattoor and Vazhachal forests in Kerala last year, died of "natural accidental causes," according to a special investigation team report. The animals might have slipped after heavy rain and died due to the impacts of the fall, the report said. The SIT concluded that the deaths were due to "natural accidental causes", citing post-mortem reports and field observations that linked the incident to episodes of extreme rainfall causing flash floods in a steep, waterfall-dominated river system.

Bonalu beckons



People dressed as the Hindu deity 'Pothuraju' dance as devotees proceed towards the Sri Jagadamba Mahakali Temple during the 'Ashada Masam Bonalu' festival celebration at the Golconda Fort in Hyderabad on Sunday. PTI

Hearts melt as Karnataka rivals put relationships, compassion over politics

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

The death of Chennamma Deve Gowda, wife of former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda, which has plunged her family into grief, also witnessed compassion and human relations gaining importance over politics among Karnataka's politicians as arch political rivals paid a visit to Mr. Gowda's residence.

Former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, who had worked with Mr. Gowda during his stint with the Janata Parivar, is one of the strongest political opponents of Mr. Gowda and the Janata Dal (S) led by him. But Mr. Siddaramaiah did not lose any time in rushing to Mr. Gowda's residence.



Words of solace: Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah consoling former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda. PTI

Mr. Siddaramaiah wiped Mr. Gowda's tears and held his hands while gently consoling him. Earlier, he took to social media, where he showered praises on Ms. Chennamma.

Mr. Siddaramaiah was accompanied by former Minister N. Cheluvarayasu. He too is often seen

attacking Mr. Gowda's son and Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, who is involved in a political tussle over the contentious Bidadi Township project, called on Mr. Gowda along with his wife. The Shivakumar family went to Mr. Gowda's resi-

Karnataka CM puts State officials on drought alert

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Issuing a stern warning to officials against slacking or negligence in handling the drought situation, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday said that drinking water, fodder for animals, insurance for crop losses, and sinking of borewells to mitigate water problems in rural areas should be the top priorities.

Speaking to Deputy Commissioners and Chief Executive Officers of zilla panchayats during a video conference on Sunday, he said farmers should not suffer because of official apathy, and that any slacking or negligence would not be tolerated.

"In the coming days, we should be prepared to handle any crisis arising out of drought. All the data and statistics will be cross-checked with the ground reality. So don't just give numbers without verification," the Chief Minister said.

Deficit rainfall

He added, "Our government is proactively engaging with all stakeholders to help the farming sector during this period. Karnataka is facing a massive rainfall deficit. Sowing is at 32%, and except for about six districts (of the total 31 districts in the State), all other districts are facing deficient rainfall. Water levels in reservoirs are starting at dead storage. The priority remains drinking water."

Amid outrage, Kerala Minister clears the air on DYFI food packets

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Facing intense outrage, Health Minister K. Muraliedharan on Sunday flipped on his opposition to the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI)'s free "pothichoru" (food parcel) distribution in over 60 government hospitals in Kerala.

On Saturday, Mr. Muraliedharan had said that the government would stop the distribution of food packets in hospitals under the banner of political parties. He said the government would start community kitchens.

By Sunday, the Minister's office issued a clarification on the issue. "The Minister's statement was regarding the Government Medical College in Alappuzha, where some organisations have encroached upon the land in the name of food distribution. The government's wish is that the poor get food."

DYFI national president A.A. Rahim told *The Hindu* that governments across the world usually attempt to get community organisations involved in the health sector, but the UDF government has unfortunately taken an opposite view.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

K.K. SRINIVASAN, 95, Retired Assistant Director of Survey and Land Records passed away on 19/7/26. Rituals on 20/07/2026 at 8 am at K.K. Nagar. Ct. 9444077498, 9840904738

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Your unassuming, sincere & human approach won many hearts. Miss your smiling face!

Amma, Sowjanya, Santosh & Family

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DAVIS THOMAS

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Maturing approach

India needs to use market access in the U.K. to raise its market share

The India-U.K. Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) reflects New Delhi's more mature approach to free trade negotiations. Unlike its 2009 free trade agreement (FTA) with ASEAN, which tilted the trade balance against India, New Delhi has approached the U.K. pact by attempting to balance liberalisation with domestic sensitivities amid an increasingly fragmented global trading system. A similar shift was evident in the New Zealand FTA, where India succeeded in protecting its sensitive dairy sector despite dairy products being one of New Zealand's biggest exports. While the India-U.K. CETA is expected to strengthen India's export competitiveness, its benefits are likely to be uneven across sectors and could place competitive pressure on already cost-disadvantaged MSMEs. The pact, an attempt to secure long-term market access and integrate India further into global value chains, offers zero-duty access on 99% of India's exports, covering almost the entire value of bilateral trade. However, smaller firms often lack the documentation and compliance capacity needed to claim these benefits. Despite the deal including some agreements on non-tariff aspects, MSMEs may find it difficult to comply with the U.K.'s stringent sanitary, phytosanitary, technical and sustainability standards, which could prove a bigger hurdle than tariffs. Globally, such agreements have accelerated export diversification, attracted investment and facilitated technology transfer, but only when supported by robust industrial ecosystems and competitive firms. India has historically underutilised several trade agreements because of low awareness, cumbersome administration and high compliance costs. The trade deficit with ASEAN widened from about \$10 billion in 2017 to nearly \$44 billion in 2023. Similarly, the U.K. agreement's benefits may remain below expectations unless India strengthens regulatory administration, intellectual property protection and dispute resolution. Although the U.K. accounts for only about 3% of India's merchandise exports and around 1% of its imports, the U.K. pact expands India's access to a high-income market where it enjoys a merchandise trade surplus. However, this advantage could narrow if imports of the U.K.'s relatively price-inelastic exports, such as luxury vehicles, grow faster than India's largely labour-intensive, price-sensitive exports. The Double Contribution Convention benefits Indian IT and professional services firms, but its economy-wide benefits may remain modest. The pact also faced a hurdle over the U.K.'s steel safeguard quotas before implementation, underlining how non-tariff measures can dilute market access. India's carbon-intensive exports could face challenges as climate-related trade regulations become more stringent. Ultimately, CETA's success lies in turning market access into market share.

Spreading wings

Vikram-I is an engineering triumph seeking commercial viability

The launch of the Vikram-I rocket built by Skyroot Aerospace from Sriharikota marked the Indian private sector's first orbital flight. Vikram-I is a four-stage launcher designed to provide what Skyroot has called a "cab service" for satellites, letting customers pick their orbit and launch schedule rather than accept the orbital slot and drop-off point presented by rideshares, at a commensurate premium. Skyroot is targeting a price per launch below that of the PSLV and above that of the SSLV (projected), to be achieved in part by basing the rocket on carbon-composite structures. It also has plans for a more powerful Vikram-2 rocket. The company was founded in 2018 by two former ISRO engineers and its path to orbit followed engine tests in 2020 and a suborbital flight in 2022. For roughly six decades, ISRO held a state monopoly over launch activities in India while private firms were limited to being suppliers. Reforms since 2020 and the 2023 Space Policy opened the door for commercial players and freed ISRO to focus on R&D and scientific missions. In 2024, up to 49% FDI in launch vehicles was allowed by the automatic route. The push is also part of the government's ambition of growing the national space economy to \$44 billion by 2033 from around \$8 billion alongside satellite manufacturing, communications, navigation, and earth observation. Orbital launch capability remains hard-won: India is now only the third country to host private enterprise that has demonstrated it. But now that Skyroot has proved competence in engineering, its next milestone is commercial viability, which may be harder. Specifically, the company has to demonstrate repeatability and stable launch costs in an increasingly crowded suppliers' market that includes established 'brands' such as SpaceX and Rocket Lab and a bevy of rapidly scaling Chinese firms. Rideshares on larger rockets are still often cheaper per kilogram to orbit. The model Skyroot is betting on, letting customers specify orbit and schedule in return for a premium over a rideshare launch, depends on a market of uncertain size. The greater production scale will challenge the engineering, too, as batch-to-batch variability becomes harder to control. India also lacks a Space Activities Act, leaving liability to be governed by policy, contracts, existing law, and international commitments rather than statute, maintaining long-term regulatory uncertainty, particularly in the event of a launch or orbital mishap. The Vikram-I launch is an engineering triumph. Whether it translates to commercial success, which is the real national ambition, is now the question.

India has one of the world's largest youth populations (371 million, according to United Nations data of 2025), often described as a demographic dividend. But this demographic dividend is only a promise and does not guarantee an automatic outcome. It pays off only when the transition occurs, enabling young people to move from classrooms into decent, productive work with higher skills. Right now, that transition is faltering, and the evidence is visible in Gen Z's employment patterns. The term 'Gen Z' refers to individuals born between 1997 and 2012. They succeeded the Millennials (also known as Generation Y), who were born between 1981 and 1996. The working-age population for Gen Z broadly falls within the 15-26 age group, while Millennials are aged between the years 27 to 42. According to the 2023-24 Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), India has an estimated 29.94 crore working-age Gen Z individuals (aged 15-26 years), compared with 35 crore Millennials (aged 27-42 years). Using the same datasets, we analyse their occupational patterns, labour force participation rates, unemployment levels, and access to social security systems.

Gen Z work status
PLFS 2023-24 estimates show that a large share of Gen Z remains engaged in education. The data show that 41.7% of young males and 38.4% of young females are studying. While this partly explains their delayed entry into the labour market, the situation of the remaining youth is a cause for concern. When young people do enter the labour market, many are absorbed into non-salaried and casual forms of employment. Among young males, 15.8% are engaged as unpaid family workers, 12.3% are in casual work – possibly with segments of the informal economy – and only 14.8% are regular wage earners. Among female Gen Z individuals, about 35% are engaged in domestic duties (out of the labour force), 10.7% work as unpaid family workers, and only 4.7% are regular wage earners. These patterns underline the fact that women bear this burden disproportionately. Among Gen Z females, 27.1% are engaged in domestic duties only, compared with just 0.32% of males. Even where women want paid work, they face higher unemployment and weaker labour market attachment. This is not only a matter of jobs. It also reflects childcare burdens, safety concerns, mobility constraints and social norms, and the design of work itself. India cannot talk seriously about harnessing its demographic advantage while leaving such a large share of young women outside the paid economy. What happens when young people try to enter



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Celebrating India's demographic dividend means little when Gen Z faces unemployment, insecurity and shrinking pathways to decent work

the labour market? The answer is concerning: too many of them are unable to find adequate employment opportunities. The first indicator to consider is the labour force participation rate (LFPR). Among Gen Z, 41.7% are in the labour force, against 75% of Millennials. Within Gen Z, rural participation (44.1%) exceeds urban participation (37.2%), suggesting that rural youth tend to enter the labour market earlier, whereas urban youth spend more time in education and training. A sharp gender divide is also evident. Among young males, labour force participation is 59.3% in rural India and 51.3% in urban India, compared to just 28% and 21.1% respectively for young females. The unemployment situation is even more alarming. The overall unemployment rate for Gen Z is 11.9%, compared to only 2% among Millennials. In urban India, the situation deteriorates further, with Gen Z unemployment rising to 17.1%. For urban young women, it reaches a staggering 22.6%. This is not merely a temporary labour-market friction; it is a serious warning sign that the economy is struggling to absorb young jobseekers, particularly in areas where aspirations and educational qualifications are often higher.

The graduate trap, social security mirage
For most of the youth, education offers a gateway of opportunity: more education leading to better jobs and lower unemployment. Instead, our estimate shows the opposite at the top end. Among Gen Z males with graduate-level education or above, unemployment stands at 29%. Among Gen Z females, it is even higher at 36.9%. This is the heart of India's silent jobs crisis. The country is producing educated young people faster than it is producing suitable jobs for them. A similar disparity persists among Millennials. Only 5.2% of male graduates and above are unemployed, but the corresponding figure for women is significantly higher at 13.8%. This disconnect perhaps points to a deeper mismatch between the education system and labour market requirements. While part of the problem relates to skill mismatches, it is also increasingly shaped by automation and the growing adoption of artificial intelligence, both of which are altering the nature of available jobs. That mismatch carries a deeper risk. When higher education no longer improves employment prospects quickly or reliably, frustration rises, family investment in education comes under strain, and confidence in the growth story weakens. A labour market that cannot absorb its educated youth is not just inefficient. It can become socially corrosive and

destabilising. Even for those who do find work, the quality of employment remains deeply concerning. Only 20.1% of Gen Z individuals are covered by social security, and just 14.1% have a formal job contract. Among the remaining 79.9% who lack social security coverage, only 3.2% have a job contract. Overall, only 17.3% of Gen Z workers have any form of contractual employment. This implies that most are entering the workforce without either. The challenge, therefore, is not merely unemployment but the widespread prevalence of informal, insecure, and weakly protected work. Further, in recent years, there has been growing evidence of the informalisation of formal employment among the Gen Z population. The situation among Millennials is only marginally better. Merely 26% have a job contract, while only 28.6% are covered by social security. The recent large-scale violent labour protests in Noida, Uttar Pradesh, led by industrial and factory workers demanding higher wages and better working conditions, reflect the frustration that insecure and poorly protected employment can produce.

A promise deferred
India's jobs debate is too often discussed in silos: unemployment, skilling, women's work and labour force participation, and informality. However, these are not separate problems. They are one connected failure of labour market transition. Young people (Gen Z) are staying in education longer, but the bridge from education to work is weak. Women face structural barriers that keep them out or push them into unpaid roles. And even when work is found, it is too often outside the protections of formal employment. It is time India moves beyond merely celebrating its large demographic dividend and begins treating the issue with greater urgency. Skill programmes have value, but they cannot substitute for actual job creation. The answer lies in expanding labour-intensive sectors, building stronger school-to-work pathways, linking training more closely to employers, and making it easier for women to enter and remain in paid work. Apprenticeships, formal hiring incentives, urban employment expansion, safe transport and childcare support all need to be part of the response. The numbers tell a blunt story. India's youth challenge is no longer about whether young people are ready for work. It is about whether the economy is ready for them. Until that changes, the demographic dividend will remain what it has so far been: a promise deferred.

Much more than 'Melbourne meets Modi'

In terms of rock star performances by foreign leaders, it would be hard to beat Prime Minister Narendra Modi's magnetic engagement with a Melbourne crowd in Australia in the second week of July. As one of those in the crowd, I can attest that the audience revelled in Mr. Modi's energy, and the messages of aspiration for the diaspora and for the Australia-India partnership. Mr. Modi's visit to Australia took place from July 8 to 10. But this visit was a lot more than a rock star performance. It opened new chapters in the India-Australia story – in investment, strategic trust, culture, sports and people. **Beyond symbolic diplomacy** A short call of the board is warranted. The leaders, Mr. Modi and Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese agreed on: a new Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation that deepens our work together as a force for peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific; a new Partnership on Cyber, Critical Technologies and Supply Chains that strengthens our respective cyber capabilities, improves regional and global cyber resilience, and boosts our industrial and business linkages; a sports playbook that leverages Australia's expertise in major sporting events, as India seeks to demonstrate its global leadership by hosting the Commonwealth Games and bidding for the Olympic and Paralympic Games; a statement on energy security that commits Australia and India to more resilient energy supply chains, while making possible Australian uranium exports to India for peaceful purposes, and a Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap that charts the way forward for Australia and India to expand



Philip Green
Australia's High Commissioner to India

The 'Melbourne momentum' is opening new chapters in security, business, education and culture

cooperation on maritime security in the vast Indian Ocean that lies between our shores. **Business, education, cricket** That is a lot for a single visit. And business leaders chipped in – Australia's largest pension fund, Australian Super, decided to invest half a billion dollars (that is ₹3,360 crore) in India's National Investment and Infrastructure Fund Limited. That is on top of Australia's leading hyperscalers committing to build tens of billions of dollars in data centres across India. Our education sectors reminded us that eight Australian universities have now undertaken to open foreign branch campuses in India, including the University of New South Wales (UNSW), which is a global top 20 university. When its campus opens later this year, UNSW will be the highest-ranking university in India. And a big next step in our relationship was also foreshadowed, with the plans for an annual showcase of the best of Australian culture and business under the banner "G'Day - Namaste". G'Day - Namaste will coincide with the Australian Big Bash League playing its first game (cricket) on foreign soil in December this year. To me, this rich set of outcomes represents more than a fair bit of work in preparation for the visit. It shows that there is a lot more headroom to deepen and expand our collaboration. That is because of three underlying drivers that are impelling our partnership forward: The fact that we are reliable partners at a time when our region, and the world more broadly, is in flux, and when each of us needs to find deeper international connections to safeguard our interests; the fact that we have highly complementary economies – Australia's

strengths in energy, mining, and education and skills fit neatly with India's rapidly growing manufacturing industry, and the fact that the Indian diaspora in Australia – Australia's fastest-growing – is a source of pride and dynamism for our two governments. **Leadership drives partnership** Relationships grow when the objective conditions are fertile. They flourish when each nation sees in the other, solutions to some of its problems, and pathways to maximise their opportunities. That is where Australia and India are. They also flourish when they have leadership with a shared vision and ambition for the relationship. That shared ambition was much on display between Prime Ministers Narendra Modi and Anthony Albanese. Stability and continuity are on the side of our leaders too, with each focused on fixing long-term problems and seizing opportunities. The two leaders have a deep respect and admiration for each other. The genuine warmth between our Prime Ministers was on unmistakable display over two days in Melbourne – from their banter about cricket in quiet moments, to their attentive consideration of each other's viewpoints, to the bear-hugs that caught the attention of the cameras. The visit is a vivid demonstration of what a positive place we find ourselves in, in the India-Australia partnership. Not all bilateral relationships have that just now, so we should celebrate it. Celebrate it, and recommit ourselves to maximising the opportunities of a special moment of alignment of interests.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Silencing peaceful dissent
The Delhi police's act of forcibly bundling off the fasting Sonam Wangchuk appeared deeply dehumanising towards a man engaged in a Gandhian-style satyagraha. However, the government's cold response has made its position clear: it will pay no heed to the students' demand for the resignation of the Union Education Minister. The prolonged silence has only reinforced perceptions of an authoritarian approach. **Kamal Laddha,** Bengaluru

I still remember line in my Class 9 NCERT political science textbook: "A democratic government is better because it is a more accountable form of government." Accountability means that the government should answer the people and listen to their concerns. The gathering at Jantar Mantar was a peaceful protest with one demand. Whether people agree with this demand or not, students have the right to peacefully express their concerns. Paper leaks have made students take a second look at the

education system as behind every test are months, and sometimes years, of hard work. Who will be accountable for the stress, disappointment and uncertainty that students face? Wanting a fair education system does not mean we are against India. **Sourabh Singh Shekhawat,** New Delhi

Private players lift off
Skyroot Aerospace's successful launch of Vikram-1 (Front page, July 19) marks a watershed moment in the evolution of India's space sector beyond

the Indian Space Research Organisation. However, space remains an unforgiving frontier, as reflected in the high failure rate of launch startups worldwide. To sustain this momentum, India must move beyond a single milestone to achieve reliable, high-frequency commercial launches. This will require the Government to ensure continued access to critical infrastructure, a predictable regulatory environment, and robust venture funding. **Vijaykumar H.K.,** Raichur, Karnataka

It was exhilarating to watch a merry bunch of jeans-clad youngsters achieve spectacular success. The mission was textbook-perfect, with every parameter meticulously met. One can only hope that we show the same seriousness in addressing the glitches in our education system. The gaffes surrounding the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test and other public examinations must be acknowledged with equal urgency, and accountability fixed, if we are to keep our

youth motivated and engaged in achieving sustained excellence across every field of technology and innovation. That said, United States President Donald Trump may yet come to regret his whimsical views on H-1B visas when shown images of Indians in their twenties, thriving under private entrepreneurship and demonstrating high technological excellence. **R. Narayanan,** Navi Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

India's F&O boom needs adequate protections

Headlines continue to highlight the devastating financial ruin of investors who traded in the Futures and Options (F&O) segment, as many of them get caught in a spiral of debt. Mounting financial pressure from these trading losses has recently led to multiple cases of suicide.

At their core, F&O contracts are derivatives. They allow investors to buy, sell, or lock in the price of an underlying asset such as a stock, index, or commodity at a future date without actually owning it. While institutions use these instruments to hedge existing portfolios against market downturns, many retail participants are drawn to them solely to speculate, lured by the promise of quick money.

According to SEBI reports, the average investor driving this frenzy is overwhelmingly male (86.3%), hails from small tier-2 and tier-3 cities (over 72%) and earns less than ₹5 lakh per annum (75%). A July 2025 SEBI study revealed that over 90% of individual traders incurred heavy losses over the four-year period from FY22; aggregate retail losses surpassed ₹2.8 lakh crore, with the average net loss per participant pegged above ₹4 lakh. Only 1% of retail traders managed a profit exceeding ₹1 lakh.

Rigged playing field

Over the last eight years, India has evolved from a marginal player into one of the world's largest F&O markets. This hyper-growth began during the FY16 to FY19 period, when exchanges introduced weekly-expiring contracts in addition to the traditional month-end expiries. Fuelled by a booming bull market, smooth mobile trading apps, instant UPI fund transfers, aggressive 'how-to-trade' content via social media, and cheap discount brokerages, entering the market became effortless. However, the psychological thrill of fast cash has blinded users to reality: over 75% of loss-making retail traders



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Anand Srinivasan
Deep value investor in stocks and commodities

Mature derivatives markets do not rely on warnings; they enforce strict entry barriers and suitability systems to limit speculative risks

continue to trade year after year, even after sustaining heavy losses.

Retail traders lose because they are bringing knives to a gunfight. SEBI's research reveals that 97% of institutional profits and 96% of proprietary trading profits in the Indian F&O market are generated by algorithmic trading. These institutional desks utilise lightning-fast code co-located directly inside exchange servers. Retail investors are competing against highly sophisticated, millisecond-fast automated strategies they cannot access. A July 2025 SEBI interim order banned Jane Street, an American quantitative trading firm, for index manipulation, highlighting how high-frequency traders exploit retail participants in the F&O market. Furthermore, individual traders focus purely on whether an option premium moves up or down, completely ignoring the massive layer of statutory taxes, platform fees, and transaction charges applied to every click. Over 70% of these transaction costs stem from brokerage and exchange fees. In FY24, retail traders incurred a total net loss of ₹74,800 crore. Of this, ₹22,450 crore went entirely toward transaction costs. When you strip away these costs, individual traders suffered a gross trading loss of ₹52,400 crore. Crucially, this wealth was transferred directly to the other side of the aisle: proprietary traders booked ₹33,000 crore in gross profits, while Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) took home ₹28,000 crore.

Both SEBI and the Union Government have tried to cool this market. Regulators have hiked minimum contract sizes, limited weekly expiries, mandated upfront premiums, enforced a 50% cash collateral rule, introduced stringent intra-day position monitoring and forced brokers to display prominent risk disclosures. While these initiatives caused a brief contraction in overall F&O volumes, retail investors are stubbornly staying put. In fact, NSE volumes from

May 2026 show that the proportion of individual investors in the Equity Derivatives pool actually rose by 4% year-on-year to hit 31%. As FPIs and proprietary traders reduce their exposure, retail traders are choosing to make up a larger slice of a highly volatile, shrinking pie.

The way forward

Indian regulators must now look toward global safeguards. Mature derivatives markets do not rely on warnings; they enforce strict entry barriers and suitability systems to limit speculative risks.

For example, in Singapore, the Monetary Authority of Singapore requires brokers to conduct a formal Customer Knowledge Assessment for exchange traded derivatives. Similarly, in the U.S., under the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority's Know Your Customer and Suitability Rules, broker-dealers act as legally liable gatekeepers. Brokers must bucket retail clients into strict options approval tiers based on their self-certified financial health; or face severe fines and civil liabilities if they approve unseasoned traders for complex strategies.

Therefore, to protect vulnerable citizens, SEBI must move beyond passive warnings. This regulatory courage is especially critical as the National Stock Exchange (NSE) prepares for its long-awaited public debut. With a massive portion of the NSE's IPO valuation anchored directly to the explosive transaction volumes of retail F&O trading, the exchange's commercial incentives are fundamentally at odds with investor protection. SEBI must see past the market euphoria.

The regulator should explore implementing a baseline liquid capital threshold for F&O access, establish mandatory entry exams, and place the legal responsibility of verifying investor suitability squarely on the shoulders of the discount brokerages profiting from the volume, ensuring that a public listing for the NSE does not come at the cost of financial stability.

Between power and principle

The IUML is torn between its political positions and compulsions of governance

STATE OF PLAY

Abdul Latheef Naha

The Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) has entered a difficult phase in its political journey. The party that built its politics on issues concerning the community it represents is now confronting the realities of governance. Since the United Democratic Front (UDF) returned to power in Kerala in May, the IUML has found itself defending, or remaining silent on, decisions that sit uneasily with its stated principles.

The latest example is the Waqf issue. The Kerala High Court has frozen the functioning of the Kerala State Waqf Board after finding that it was constituted in violation of the Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025. The amended law requires every State waqf board to have two non-Muslim members and one Shia Muslim member. The board had neither.

The legal issue has quickly become a political one. The State government has informed the High Court that it will reconstitute the board in accordance with the amended law. However, this position directly clashes with the IUML's stand. The party remains one of the petitioners before the Supreme Court challenging the constitutional validity of the law. It continues to oppose the provision mandating two non-Muslim members on State waqf boards. This leaves the party in an awkward position. It is fighting the law in one court while being part of a government implementing it before another.

While coalition governments survive on collective responsibility rather than ideological purity, the waqf issue cannot be sidelined as a mere



administrative matter. It concerns a question on which the IUML mobilised opinion, challenged the Centre, and projected itself as a defender of Muslim institutions. It must now own a government decision that accepts the framework it opposes.

The irony is that the legal setback also offers the party a political opportunity. The previous Left government had appointed the existing waqf board. A fresh board allows the IUML to shape its composition and bring in members of its choice. While the mandatory inclusion of two non-Muslim members goes against its policy, the party also gets a chance to replace a board it did not appoint.

Even then, the perception problem remains. Criticism from sections of the Muslim community, particularly both factions of the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama, reflects the discomfort among the IUML's support base.

A balancing act

The waqf controversy is not an isolated case. The UDF government's decision to reduce tax on beverages with low alcohol content placed the IUML in a similarly difficult position. The party has consistently opposed liquor in all forms. Yet the Cabinet, of which the IUML is a key member, approved a measure critics viewed as encouraging alcohol consumption.

The party chose coalition discipline over confrontation. While its leaders reiterated their opposition to liquor, they also made it clear that Cabinet decisions would be respected. The message sounded politically safe but not politically convincing. If a party cannot influence policy while sharing power, questions naturally arise about its weight within the coalition.

The PM SHRI issue followed the same pattern. When the Left government had explored the scheme, the IUML had rejected it outright. Some leaders had even declared that PM SHRI would be thrown into the Arabian Sea if the UDF came to power. Today, the UDF government argues that Kerala cannot afford to lose the Central funding linked to the scheme; an IUML Minister now heads the committee examining its implementation.

Taken individually, each decision can be defended as a compromise of governance. Governments cannot function if every coalition partner insists on ideological consistency. But politics is not about isolated decisions. It is about patterns. Within months of returning to office, the IUML has been forced to reconcile three long-held positions with the compulsions of governance. This creates the impression that the transition from Opposition to government has also become a transition from conviction to convenience.

Coalition politics demand compromise. But the question is how much can a party compromise before its supporters begin to ask whether the line between accommodation and abandonment has become too thin. On the waqf issue, more than any other, the IUML finds itself answering that question.

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Indians worst hit as Canada cuts down on student intake

The steady climb of Indian students going to Canada since 2015, is now witnessing a quick reversal that is likely to worsen further by the end of 2026

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

Indian students seem to be taking the biggest hit by the decision of Canada – their most preferred destination thus far – to sharply reduce the number of study permits issued to international students.

The latest data available for April 2026 showed that the number of new study permits and renewals issued to Indian students saw a 16% drop compared with last April, which itself was a striking 84% decline compared to April 2024 – an indication that opportunities for Indian students in the North American country could shrink further.

As of 2025, Canada accounted for about 34%, or one-third of the roughly 12.54 lakh Indian students studying abroad, surpassing other key destinations like the U.S, the U.K. and Australia (Chart 1).

This share is likely to witness a steep decline in the coming years with Canada's 2026-2028 Immigration Levels Plans (ILP) slashing the annual cap on issuance of new permits for foreign students by 50%, compared with its ILP for 2025-2027.

The impact was first felt in 2025 when student permits issued to Indians in April 2025 came down to just 6,895, an 81% drop from 36,510 issued in April 2024. This has further declined to 5,795 this year, of which many could be renewals (Chart 2). The disaggregated numbers on new permits and renewals are not available.

Canada was not only the most preferred destination for Indian students; Indians accounted for the largest share of foreign nationals studying in the country.

After accounting for just 14.6% of total international students in Canada in 2015, Indians overtook the Chinese in 2018 to become the single largest student immigration group in the country.

This trend of a steady increase since 2015 to a peak of 41.2% in 2022 is now witnessing a swift reversal. In a single year, the share declined sharply by 12 percentage points from 36.6 % in 2024 to 24.6% in 2025, the lowest since 2016 (Chart 3).

Major impact

It is not just Indian students who are taking the hit due to Canada's shift to allow far fewer students in its bid to bring immigration back to sustainable levels, as articulated in its 2026-2028 ILP.

The country, which saw the number of persons holding student permits tripling from about 2.2 lakh in 2015 to 6.8 lakh in 2023, has brought down the figure by 44% to 3.8 lakh in 2025 (Chart 4).

Though students from other countries have also taken a hit, the biggest impact seems to be felt by Indians. While the overall numbers of students from all countries fell by 44%, the number of Indian students fell by 66% from 2.78 lakh in 2023 to 93,915 in 2025 (Chart 5).

Moreover, a Reuters report, published in November last year, citing data from Canada's immigration department, said about 74% of Indian applications for study permits in Canada's post-secondary institutions in August 2025 were rejected, compared with about 32% in August 2023. While the overall rejection rate stood at 40% in August 2025, it was just 24% for Chinese students.

What could be worrying for Indian students aspiring to study abroad is that it is not just Canada, but that other popular destinations like the U.S, the U.K. and Australia are also tightening their policies. For instance, the number of Indian students who entered the U.K. declined by 13% in 2024-25 compared to 2023-24.

Earlier this year, Australia's Home Affairs flagged an alert for student visa applications from India, moving Indian students from evidence level 2 to evidence level 3 or the 'highest risk' category.

Entry restricted

Data for the charts were sourced from the Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRGC)'S statistics on international students and Parliament Questions and Answers



CHART 1: Country-wise share of Indians studying in universities or tertiary institutions abroad as of 2025

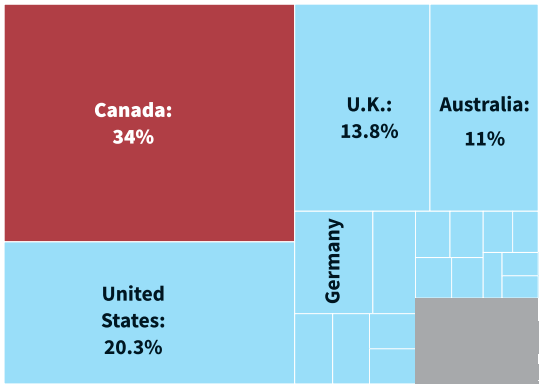


CHART 2: Study permits (new and renewals) issued to Indians every April since 2015

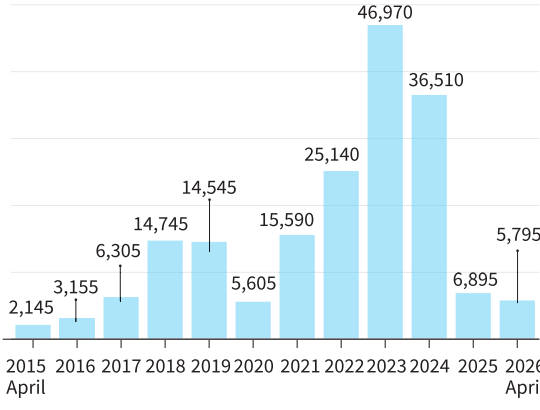


CHART 3: Indian students accounted for more than 30% of all international students in Canada since 2018. Figures in %

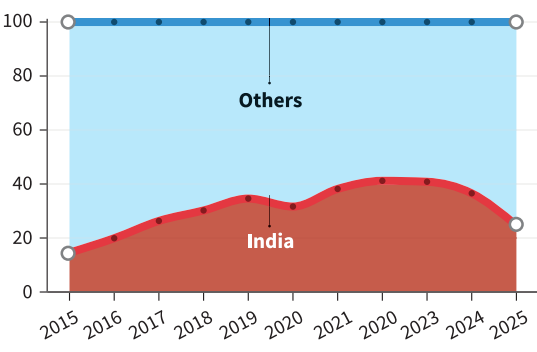


CHART 4: Total number of international study permit holders in Canada each year. Data for 2026 pertains till April

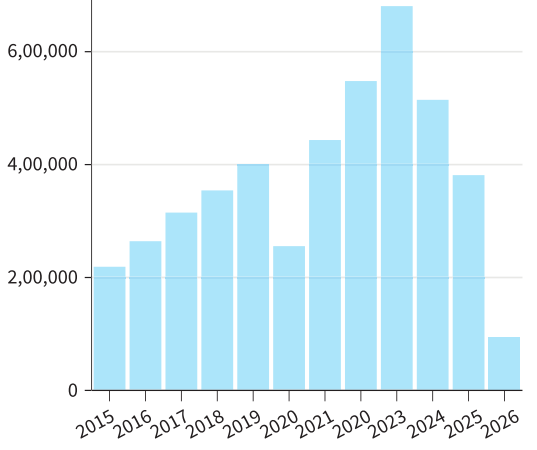
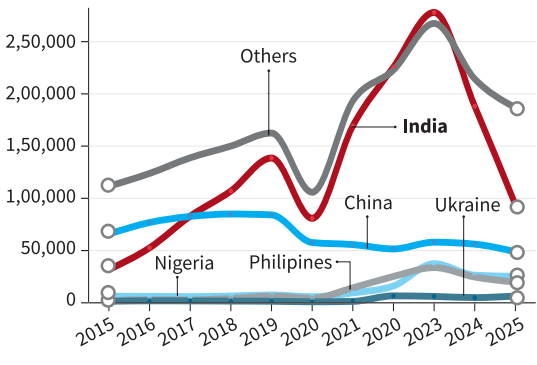


CHART 5: Country-wise study permit holders in Canada. Top five are shown separately. Rest are clubbed under 'Others'



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 20, 1976

Indian tea industry sets many records

Calcutta, July 19: The Indian tea industry has a number of records to its credit – in production, grades, price and export.

The 140-year-old industry's production rose to 490 million kg from 295-million kg in the last 20 years. This represents an annual growth of 3.2 per cent. As a result, India to-day produces more tea than the rest of the world taken together.

The country produces as many as 1,001 varieties of tea. The list in short is Assam, Darjeeling, High Range, Nilgiris, Cachars, Doors, Kanga and Mandis.

India makes every type of tea. They are tippy and wiry orthodox of North India, black stylish orthodox of South India, legg-cut instant green traditional and green Japanese-type.

On the export front, the country shipped during 1975-76 record tea worth Rs. 238 crores. The production during the year also touched a new peak of 490-million kg. Yet another record was in the export of packet tea which earned Rs. 17 crores compared to Rs. 9 crores in the previous year.

Darjeeling tea, which normally fetches the highest price because of its superior quality and flavour was sold at the Calcutta auction this year at a record price of Rs. 299 per kg.

The country has in all four auction centres at Calcutta, Cochin, Gauhati and Coonoor. Between themselves, these centres handled a total of 285.5-million kg of tea during 1975. Besides, Indian tea is auctioned in London.

Indian consumes more tea than any other country, the home market accounting for a little over 50 per cent of the total output. Consumers are supplied tea in original garden packed or blended form as required. The country has ten modern blending and packaging factories.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 20, 1926

Labourers in Ceylon

Simla, July 17: In his report for 1925, Mr. S. Ranganathan, I.C.S. Agent to the Government of India in Ceylon, observed that no less than 40 per cent of the Indian labourers in Ceylon did not receive a living wage and calls attention to the inadequacy of arrangements regarding medical relief, housing and education and urges the adoption of a standard wage.

M CH-CHE

Ahead of Monsoon Session, MPs seek debate on NEET, delimitation

Opposition parties stage a brief walkout from all-party meet in protest against invitation to breakaway Trinamool faction; seek talks on police action at Jantar Mantar, E20; Rijju tells parties to participate constructively in parliamentary debates

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

An invitation extended by Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijju to a breakaway Trinamool Congress group prompted Opposition parties to stage a walkout from the all-party meeting held on Saturday, ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

The protest brought together parties that have often been at odds, including the DMK; the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which skipped the INDIA bloc meeting on June 8; and the Left parties, which are ideologically opposed to the Trinamool. They objected to the government's decision to invite the rebel Trinamool MPs, stating that Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla had not yet recognised the group's claim that it had merged with the Tripura-based Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

The Opposition's walkout lasted for a brief while before leaders returned to the meeting and pressed for discussions on a range of issues, including the alleged theft of Ram temple donations, the NEET paper



Setting the stage: Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijju chairs a meeting with floor leaders of political parties at Parliament House on Sunday. ANI

leak controversy, ethanol-blended petrol (E20), the Delhi Police's action at Jantar Mantar to shift activist Sonam Wangchuk, the continuing hunger strike by students, and the situation in Manipur.

Mr. Rijju later said that the walkout "should not be viewed as a boycott of the entire day's proceedings; it was symbolic".

In his opening remarks, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, who chaired the meeting, lauded the BJP government for its han-

dling of the ongoing crisis triggered by the U.S.-Iran stand-off.

Delimitation Bill

Several Opposition leaders sought clarity on reports that the government could revive the Delimitation Bill in view of changes in the Lok Sabha's composition following split in the Trinamool and Shiv Sena (UBT).

DMK leader Tiruchi Siva said that his party favoured implementing the 33% reservation for women within the existing strength of

the Lok Sabha, and maintained that any delimitation exercise should not adversely affect southern States.

Mr. Rijju did not clearly say if the government would bring back the Delimitation Bill during the session, but said the matter would be discussed at the Business Advisory Committee meeting. He urged all parties to participate constructively in parliamentary discussions and support legislative business. Smooth functioning

of Parliament, he said, was in the national interest, while disruptions and sloganeering ultimately harmed both Parliament and the Opposition.

Trinamool MP Mahua Moitra questioned the basis for inviting the 20 rebel MPs. Stating that the disqualification petitions were pending, she said there was no constitutional basis for a separate bloc. Defending the invite, Mr. Rijju said the breakaway group had sought recognition from the Speaker and could not be ignored by the government.

Among other demands, Samajwadi Party MP Dharmendra Yadav sought discussion on the alleged theft of Ram temple donations. CPI(M) leader John Brittas criticised the "BJP-engineered split" in Opposition parties, arguing that they weakened democratic representation. CPI leader P. Sandosh Kumar sought a discussion on "large-scale deletions" of voters' names during the SIR.

A total of 58 leaders from 40 political parties attended the meeting. The Monsoon Session begins on Monday and will conclude on August 13.

Centre has to align what it says on delimitation with what is written in the Bill

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George
NEW DELHI

Though there is no official word on it yet, the Centre appears eager to initiate the delimitation exercise by amending the Constitution and passing a Delimitation Bill. In April, the Centre moved the 131st Constitutional Amendment Bill and the Delimitation Bill, which in combination proposed the following:

Increase the strength of the Lok Sabha to a maximum of 850 seats.

Allot those seats among States based on the population figures of the "latest Census" (which happens to be that of 2011) and delimit individual constituencies within each State immediately. As per the existing provisions of the Constitution, a fresh allocation among States and delimitation can happen only after the Census of 2027.

Reserve one-third of the Lok Sabha seats for women, which would otherwise happen along with the fresh delimitation after the 2027 Census.

The Bills moved by the government did not align with the oral promises made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah on the floor of Parliament and in interactions with representatives of political parties. The government has publicly maintained that its delimitation plans would not affect the existing proportion of individual States in the Lok Sabha, and that the proposed 50% increase in the size of the Lok Sabha would translate into a 50% increase in the number of seats in each State. Since that promise was in conflict with the text of the proposed amendments in April, no consensus could



The 131st Constitutional Amendment Bill and the Delimitation Bill proposes to increase the Lok Sabha strength to 850. PTI

be reached for the passage of the Constitution amendment, which requires a two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha. The amendment Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha, and the Delimitation Bill was not put to vote.

The question, therefore, as Parliament convenes for a new session, is how the text of the Constitution can incorporate the promise of maintaining the current proportional distribution of Lok Sabha seats.

The existing proportion of seats for each State is a constitutional guarantee written into Articles 81 and 82 of the Constitution. That guarantee has a sunset clause – the existing arrangement comes to an automatic end once the data of the first Census after 2026 is published.

In Articles 81 and 82, there are references to three Censuses: the first Census after 2026; the Census of 1971; and the Census of 2001. The next delimitation is tied to the first Census after 2026; the existing proportion of Lok Sabha seats among States is tied to the 1971 Census; and the population of individual constituencies within the States is tied to the 2001 Census. The April amendments and the Delimitation Bill, in combination, proposed to remove all these separate references and tie the allotment of seats to the States and the delimitation of constituencies to the "latest Census".

If the Centre wants to make good on its verbal assurance of maintaining the existing proportional share of each State in the Lok Sabha, it must extend the freeze that ends in 2026 into the future. The last two times, the freeze was imposed for 25 years each – in 1976 until 2001, and in 2001 until 2026. If the Centre plans to freeze the current arrangement for another 25 years, the references to the first Census after 2026 in Articles 81 and 82 can be amended to read "after 2051". Or it can be any other date into the future, as the case may be.

To ensure that each State gets a 50% increase in seats, the reference to the 1971 Census in Articles 81 and 82 would also need to be retained, unless the government has another formulation to achieve that objective. If the Centre wants to propose a fresh delimitation while retaining the existing proportion of seats and only redrawing constituency boundaries within each State, it can retain the references to the 1971 Census where they exist now in Articles 81 and 82 and amend the references to the 2001 Census to the 2011 Census. This way, the constitutional guarantee of the proportional strength of States can be extended while paving the way for a fresh delimitation of constituencies within State boundaries, and kicking off women's reservation.

Silence on Ram Temple theft unacceptable: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Saying that lakhs of devotees are feeling betrayed by the alleged embezzlement of donations from the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the Congress has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to conduct "an independent and comprehensive investigation of financial affairs" of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, including the han-

dling of all offerings.

"You are aware of the theft of thousands of crores in the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. Lakhs of devotees who donated their hard-earned money with faith, devotion and trust are feeling betrayed by the theft," said a joint letter by Congress president and the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Mallikarjun Kharge, and his party colleague and the Lead-

er of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, to the Prime Minister.

The letter, dated July 18 and released on Sunday, a day before the Monsoon Session of Parliament gets under way, appears to have set the stage for a stormy political discourse.

Call for accountability

The Trust was set up by the Prime Minister on the instructions of the Supreme Court, but its members

were entirely selected by the government, the Congress leaders said.

"It is public knowledge that the members of the Trust are affiliated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) and its affiliates. Its disgraced former General Secretary was also your close associate. Your silence now in the face of such a crime is unacceptable. It is your duty to ensure accountability and

restitution," they said.

"The findings and the Trust's accounts should be made public so that every devotee knows how their offerings have been utilised. All those found responsible must be held accountable, irrespective of position or influence. The credibility of your government and the Trust rests on how transparently and swiftly you act. The people of India are watching," they said.

DMK, TDP should uphold their legacy of ensuring fair delimitation, says Ramesh

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Invoking the role played by the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in previous rounds of delimitation, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the two parties should not fritter away their legacy of ensuring fairness in the delimitation process.

Speaking to *The Hindu* ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, Mr. Ramesh said continuing with the 1971 Census as the basis for the distribution of Lok Sabha seats is crucial to maintaining the federal balance. The Congress, he said, favours extending the freeze for another 25 years.

"The DMK played a pivotal role in the Constitutional freeze of 1976. The DMK and the TDP played a crucial role in the Constitutional freeze of 2001. Hopefully both will now continue to play the key role in ensuring there is no unfreezing," he said.

On April 17, the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, which sought to redistribute Lok Sabha seats on the basis of the 2011 Census and expedite the implementation of women's reservation, was defeated by



Jairam Ramesh

Congress, and it remains unclear how it would vote if the Bill returns to Parliament. The TDP, a key BJP ally, too has advocated for retention of the 1971 reference in the legislation.

'Optical illusion'

The Congress leader said the oral assurance given by Home Minister Amit Shah in the last session regarding a proportionate 50% increase in the Lok Sabha representation of every State was only an "optical illusion" created by the government. The assurance was not reflected in the Bills circulated during the last session.

"The talk of a proportionate 50% increase... is meaningless in the light of Article 81(2)(a)," Mr. Ramesh said, arguing that the government, through the Bills defeated in the last session, had removed the constitutional protection for maintaining the State-wise proportion of seats in the Lok Sabha.

"The Bills circulated by the government in the last session removed the constitutional freeze on the distribution of Lok Sabha seats, which means that it is now a constitutional imperative to reallocate seats in favour of more populous States," Mr. Ramesh said.

In fond memory of
Sri P. BRAHMAYYA GARU
on the occasion of the
FORTY SIXTH
Death Anniversary



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Passed away: 20-07-1980
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2	2026_KMML_861243_1	Supply of Squirrel cage Induction Motor

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TENDER NOTICE

Bids are invited from reputed and experienced agencies for "Development, Operation and Maintenance of Premium Desert Caravan Park in Dhordo, Kutch, Gujarat"

The project requirements, technical specifications, eligibility criteria, selection process, etc. are included in the Tender documents, which shall be available for download from the websites: <https://tender.nprocure.com/> and <https://www.gujarattourism.com> from 20/07/2026 onwards.

The last date for submission of the **Technical Bid and Financial Bid (online only)** is 10/08/2026 up to 6:00 pm. and **Technical Bid (physical only)** is 12/08/2026 up to 3:00 pm.

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Scan or visit newsth.live/SSSUB to subscribe and read the latest edition: **'THE MORTALITY OF GREATNESS'**

President Droupadi Murmu on Sunday embarked on state visits to Moldova, North Macedonia, and Romania to deepen India's ties with the three European countries across a range of sectors, including trade and technology, and to boost people-to-people ties. The first leg of her tour begins with a visit to Moldova on Monday, marking the first-ever visit by an Indian President to the eastern European nation. The Rashtrapati Bhavan posted a message on X, saying, "This is the first-ever visit by an Indian President to Moldova and North Macedonia. The visit to Romania by the President is taking place after a gap of over three decades." PTI

The CBI on Sunday arrested a man for allegedly impersonating an official of the Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying. The accused demanded and collected bribes from applicants seeking loans under the Animal Husbandry Infrastructure Development Fund. The accused, identified as Prabhu Dayal, claimed that he had been posted in the Department's Krishi Bhawan office. The accused allegedly sought a bribe of ₹45,000 from the complainant, equivalent to 2% of the ₹22,50,000 loan the latter had applied for. The complainant runs a poultry farm in Lalpur village in Uttarakhnad's Udham Singh Nagar. He had applied for the loan through the Udyami Mitra portal.

The matter has been posted for further hearing on Wednesday.

Mandatory registration
As per the draft Bill, it will be mandatory to register marriages and divorces across all communities through government portals, to ensure marital rights, alimony and other legal protections.

live-in relationships will be considered legitimate and entitled to full inheritance rights. If the male partner abandons the woman, she can claim maintenance—just like a legal wife—through a competent court,” the official said.

Shabdalo celebrates India's 22 official languages and traces their journey from oral traditions and ancient manuscripts to printed works and modern electronic texts, highlighting the country's enduring linguistic diversity.

During an altercation in 2017, one of them repeat-

The court said that to qualify as “obscenity”

may be affiliated to the Board of Secondary Education, the Council of Higher Secondary Education, the Central Board of Secondary Education or otherwise; college and higher education institutes, in-

statements to obtain enhanced credit facilities, siphoned and diverted loan funds, and resorted to evergreening of accounts, thereby causing a wrongful loss to bank," the CBI said.

FAITH

Efficacy of chanting

The great Acharyas have taught that in this Kali Yuga, listening to spiritual discourses, studying sacred scriptures, reading the Itihasas, performing daily parayanam, and visiting temples all have one common purpose – to keep our minds constantly absorbed in the remembrance of Bhagavan, said Sri Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. Whatever we repeatedly practise throughout our lives naturally comes to our mind at the final moment. Therefore, Nama Sankirtanam, the chanting of the Lord's divine names, is regarded as one of the most powerful spiritual practices. This truth is beautifully illustrated in the Bhagavata Purana through the story of Ajamila.

Ajamila was originally a virtuous personality who spoke the truth, controlled his senses, respected elders, remained pure in thought, word, and deed, and lived a disciplined life. However, due to bad association, he became attached to a courtesan, abandoned his righteous path, lost his wealth, and committed numerous sinful acts. His youngest son was named Narayana. At the time of his death, when the messengers of God of death arrived to take him to Yamaloka, Ajamila cried out, "Narayana!" intending to call his son. Yet, because he uttered the Lord's divine name, the messengers of Lord Vishnu immediately appeared and stopped the Yamadutas, declaring that one who chants the holy name of Narayana at life's final moment becomes eligible for the Lord's grace. This episode reveals the immeasurable glory of the divine name.

In Srīmad Bhagavatam, the grandsire Bhishma tells Dharmaputra that chanting the Lord's names is the highest form of dharma, especially in the Kali Yuga.

Insurers’ investments: should you care?

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

Last week some insurers asked the regulator to ease proposed investment norms in unlisted firms.

They wanted a higher quantum of investible funds to be allowed in unlisted firms by tweaking a certain basis of calculation proposed. Regulator IRDAI lays down investment norms and different view points and requirements lead to the dialogues.

All large firms, apart from core business, also maintain an investment portfolio spanning the securities markets, government debt, money market, international currency and so on. The income from that is called ‘other income.’

Large investment portfolios

Insurers have significantly large investment portfolios and are big institutional investors.

The premium is invested and it is with that income the insurers run operations, sell more policies and pay claims. This is because it is a long and difficult road to profit in core insurance business, called underwriting profit. And in general insurance, underwriting profit can be elusive even after decades since they deal with catastrophic and long-tail risks which can be difficult to quantify and manage.

This is why insurance norms take a strict view of investments by insurers. The percentage of total investment in each category of investment is laid out. The overarching goal of this norm is fund safety not high returns.

Investment in securities

However, since profit is also important, the regulations allow a certain, measured, portion of the portfolio to be invested in the securities market and some other instruments where the risk is higher and so is the chance of reward.

Investment in unlisted companies is considered riskier than in listed companies, other things being equal. Yet, they can give impressive returns as we have seen in the case of tech startups and the unicorns.

So, what does all this have to do with you, an individual? And this page, which is about personal finance? You should be aware of how your money is safeguarded. Because, investment is not a one-size-fits-all activity.

A case in point, years ago, a young relative came home to give my mother the good news that he had got a job in the marketing team of a mutual fund.

When he learnt of my insurance background, he complained bitterly that insurance companies were not allowed (then) to invest in mutual funds and that the insurers were losing out a golden investment opportunity (and he, a golden sale!).

I explained to him that the insurance company was investing his personal life insurance premium and asked how safe he wanted that money to be, right up to the day when a claim is made. The penny dropped and he accepted that all investments are not for everyone.

Difficult business

There are many reasons why insurance is a difficult business. It requires large investments, significant staying power until breakeven which can be over a decade later, sustained marketing and repeated shoring up of solvency as per regulations.

With all this pressure for continuing investment, your funds need to be safeguarded and that is what the regulations do.

They ensure that your money is in a safe investment until you call for it by way of a claim.

You definitely don’t want to see it frittered away on some dubious investment or shiny ponzi scheme as my neighbour did with his retirement settlement and found himself figuratively on the streets.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



ILLUSTRATION- SAAI

Electronic Gold Receipts: a new way to own gold

The yellow metal has long gone digital, but this time it is offering the convenience of electronic investing along with ownership of physical gold

NEW AGE GOLD

Vaishali R. Venkat

In May 2026, the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) introduced Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs), a new exchange-traded segment for buying and selling gold in electronic form. The initiative aims at improving transparency in gold pricing, standardise quality, and provide investors with a regulated and secure way to own the yellow metal, while making India's gold market more efficient. It enables investors to own physical gold without the need to store it at home or in a bank locker.

Gold exchange journey

On September 28, 2021, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) approved the framework for Gold Exchange and SEBI (Vault Managers) Regulations, 2021. The Centre notified EGRs as securities under the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956, in December 2021. Further, on April 11, 2022, SEBI issued a ‘Comprehensive Risk Management Framework’ for EGRs. Together, they laid the regulatory foundation for EGR trading in India.

In September 2022, the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) received SEBI's final nod to unveil the EGR segment. It became the first bourse in India to launch EGR on October 24, 2022 on Muhurat trading ses-



Retail investors, jewellers, bullion traders, refiners, institutional investors and other eligible market participants can buy EGRs via registered stockbrokers

sion. Initially, BSE introduced two EGR products backed by 995 and 999 purity gold with trading in multiples of 1 gram and physical delivery in multiples of 10/100 grams.

What are EGRs?

Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs) are exchange-traded securities representing ownership of physical gold (specified purity) stored in SEBI-regulated vaults. They can be held electronically in a demat account, bought and sold in different denominations on the bourse and converted into physical gold via prescribed process.

Buying/selling EGRs

EGRs can be traded from Monday to Friday during market hours. Trading is available from 9 a.m. to 11:30 p.m., or up to 11:55 p.m., during the U.S. daylight saving period. Like shares, EGRs follow a T+1 settlement cycle with the receipts credited to the buyer's demat account the next trading day. Retail investors, jewellers, bullion traders, refiners, institutional investors and other eligible market partici-



One of the biggest advantages is, EGRs enable transparent price discovery via exchange trading, ensuring uniform price across India at any point in time

pants can buy EGRs via registered stockbrokers. Investors need both trading and demat accounts to buy and sell EGRs.

Benefits of EGRs

EGRs combine the advantages of physical gold with the convenience of electronic investing. As a SEBI-recognised security, each EGR is backed by a specified quantity of gold of a defined purity, securely stored in SEBI-regulated vaults. This offers a transparent and standardised way to own gold while removing concerns over purity and personal storage.

One of the biggest advantages is EGRs enable transparent price discovery via exchange trading, ensuring uniform price across India at any given point in time. Investors can buy and sell EGRs during market hours, hold them in a demat account and choose from denominations based on budget. The gold backing an EGR is stored safely in regulated vaults, so investors need not worry about its purity.

Those who prefer physical gold can convert EGRs into gold whenever need-

ed. EGRs offer liquidity, settlement guarantee, fungibility and can help diversify investment portfolios.

The EGRs are available in two purity standards: 999 (99.9% pure gold) and 995 (99.5% pure gold). In each purity category, investors have six different denominations such as 10 mg, 100 mg, 1 g, 10 g, 100 g and 1 kg. Whether you want to test the waters with a tiny investment or accumulate over time, EGRs offer denominations to suit first-time buyers and seasoned investors.

Costs to bear

Apart from the cost of purchasing EGRs, investors may also incur brokerage, demat (depository) and vault-storage charges and other applicable transaction charges. Those opting for physical delivery of gold may also have to bear purity testing and transportation charges. There is no GST for EGR trading. However, investors opting for physical delivery must pay 3% GST on gold value.

Buying and selling EGRs is only one part of the story. The real questions lie behind the scenes: Why did India create a Gold Exchange? How does physical gold become an Electronic Gold Receipt? And should EGRs find a place in your portfolio? Behind every EGR lies a vault. The story behind its doors will unfold in the next part.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 99
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers of group credit life insurance

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)*
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra**	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.14-11.64	10,172 - 11,031	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.65-9.00	10,055 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*50% waiver on processing fee till Sept 30

**0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers, customers with at least 6 months banking relationship

***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on July 15

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Mbappe becomes World Cup all-time top scorer with 22 goals



Bellingham becomes England's highest goal-scorer in a World Cup



India, England players wear black armbands as tribute to Sobers



New Zealander Fox clinches British Open in dramatic finale



England trades blows with France, seals third place

The jury is still out on hydration breaks, says Wenger

Rohit's classy century not enough as England takes series in a run-fest

CM
YK



Means a lot: Sindhu said the win over Yamaguchi was special. AFP

Sindhu wins maiden Japan Open title

The 31-year-old combines relentless attack with tactical discipline and composure to tame Yamaguchi and end a 19-month title drought

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
TOKYO

P.V. Sindhu produced a vintage display of attacking badminton to outclass local favourite Akane Yamaguchi in straight games, clinching her maiden Super 750 title at the Japan Open here on Sunday.

The 31-year-old became the first Indian to win the Japan Open, combining relentless attack with tactical discipline and composure in the decisive moments to register a 21-17, 21-17 victory over the three-time World champion and end a title drought.

"I'm very happy. I'm out of words as it has been 19 months since I won a title," said Sindhu after the

match. "I think this one was very important to me because playing in the finals, coming to the finals is one thing but I think to win, stand on the podium and get that gold is a different thing.

"I'm happy that I'm on the positive side of the result and I think this will give me a lot of confidence. I'm very thankful to my coach, my parents, my support staff and of course my husband."

Sindhu's previous title came at the Syed Modi International in 2024.

The triumph is her biggest title since winning the World Championships in 2019.

She had won the Singapore Super 500 in 2022.

Yamaguchi was appearing in her sixth Japan Open final, while Sindhu had not beaten the Japanese in a

completed match in four years. Their meeting at the Malaysia Open earlier this year ended with Yamaguchi retiring after the opening game.

Sindhu's last full-match victory over her came at the Thailand Open in 2022.

On Sunday, however, the Indian dictated terms from the outset.

She controlled the forecourt superbly, attacked with purpose rather than sheer power and repeatedly found answers whenever Yamaguchi threatened a comeback.

Along with her powerful smashes, Sindhu's precise net play proved decisive. She repeatedly worked the shuttle tight to the net, forcing Yamaguchi to lift and creating opportunities to unleash her trademark cross-court and body smashes.

Sindhu targets a sixth Worlds medal next

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

A title after 20 months is perhaps the best preparation P.V. Sindhu could hope for in the run-up to the prestigious World Championships at home.

Becoming the first ever Indian winner of the Japan Open on Sunday, a Super750 event, against home favourite Akane Yamaguchi was made more special by the fact that this was Sindhu's first win in a completed match against Yamaguchi in four years. More importantly, it was Sindhu's first World Tour title outside India in four years, since the 2022 Singapore

Open. "It has been a long time, almost two years... and it feels really special. There was a lot of hard work, on and off the court. I suffered injuries and struggled with a lot of niggles, fought to get fit and competitive. We play hard on the court but there is a lot more that happens off it, and I believe there cannot be a better run-up to the World Championships," Sindhu said in a virtual interaction on Sunday.

The intensity of the achievement can be gauged from the fact that Sindhu, not the most expressive player, was teary-eyed after the match. "I had tears in my eyes be-

cause it was very, very important for me to win. I kept believing I could do it. Even though a lot of people were asking if I was 'done', I still believed in myself, my family, my coaches, and my support staff," she admitted, crediting coach Irwansyah, strength and conditioning trainer Wayne Lombard and her family.

Sindhu is now aiming to be the first shuttler ever to win an unprecedented six World Championships medals and her second title at home. "I'd want to do that and doing so at home would make it special. But I have the China Open before that, and at the moment I am focusing on it".

Becoming a GM a 'big moment' for Rathanvel

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

He was named after Ratan Tata, a titan among Indian industrialists. V.S. Rathanvel, India's newly-minted Grandmaster, didn't take after his businessman-father and instead showed a fascination for chess and as it has turned has been rather good at it.

"I started to play with my mother and, from there, they enrolled me in an academy. That's how it started," he said about his initiation into the game at the age of six.

The Coimbatore player, who became the country's 99th GM, had to endure a long wait to achieve the title despite having earned the third norm in 2022 as



Rathanvel.

he couldn't breach the 2500 Elo mark in live ratings. Rathanvel said it was due to pressure but was happy to join the elite list now.

"The closer I got, the pressure got to me. I was probably four or five times very close to 2500 and didn't cross it," he said, re-

flecting on the gap in gaining the coveted GM title.

"Becoming a Grandmaster is a big moment for me... it will also help in getting invitations for open tournaments."

The big moment came when he reached the threshold rating of 2500 at the Smart City Open in Guwahati.

He was trained by DhanaSekhar and Krishnamoorthy initially and has been working with GMs Vishnu Prasanna, M. Shyam Sunder and N. Srinath, and credits them for crossing the line.

Rathanvel, a Mechanical Engineering graduate, said he had identified a few areas where he can get better as he looks to engineer his way to bigger things.



No breakthrough: The clash between Abdusattorov and Gukesh ended in a stalemate. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Gukesh, Abdusattorov split the point

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

The clash between World champion D. Gukesh and Nodirbek Abdusattorov in the fourth round had drawn the attention of chess aficionados when the pairings for the Chennai Grand Masters at The Westin Velachery were out. The two, who have been involved in some intriguing battles over the years, played out a 41-move stalemate on Sunday when draws were the order of the day.

While the focus was on Gukesh's joust with the former World rapid champion, Alireza Firouzja was held to a draw by American Hans Niemann. The result saw the Frenchman maintain the top spot with three points, just ahead of Indian GM Arjun Erigaisi, who survived a wobble against young compatriot M. PraneSh.

Nihal Sarin's sequence of draws continued as he shared the point again with Russian GM Dmitry An-

dreikin. The two have drawn all their four games thus far.

The Abdusattorov-Gukesh match saw the former playing white and opting for the Ragozin Defence. The Indian chose a solid defensive play to prevent his opponent from gaining an early advantage. The middle-game saw the exchange of several pieces and reduced the attacking options though the queens remained on the board till the end, resulting in honours being shared.

Gukesh takes on countryman Arjun in the fifth round as he searches for his first victory.

The all-Indian fixture between Arjun and PraneSh saw the latter gain the initiative briefly before his more experienced rival fought back to restore parity and walked away with half a point.

The results:

Fourth round: Hans Niemann (USA) 1.5 drew with Alireza Firouzja (Fra) 3; Dmitry Andreikin (Rus) 2 drew with Nihal Sarin 2; Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzb) 2 drew with D. Gukesh 1.5; Arjun Erigaisi 2.5 drew with M. PraneSh 1.5.

TNCA pays tribute to Sir Garfield Sobers

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

R. Ashwin turned out for Bunts CC in its TNCA second division league match against Komaleeswarar CC on Sunday. Though the former India off-spinner went wicketless, returning figures of 10-0-63-0, Bunts cruised to a 123-run victory,

thanks to opener K. Rajkumar's 111.

Earlier in the day, Tamil Nadu Cricket Association paid tribute to the late Sir Garfield Sobers, who passed away on Friday, by observing a two-minute silence before the start of play in all league championship matches and the Freyer Cup tournament.

SNAPSHOTS

Kajal bags 76kg gold; silver for Antim, Neha
BUDAPEST: Reigning U-20 world champion wrestler Kajal clinched the women's 76kg category gold in the Budapest Ranking Series. The high-stakes encounter against USA's Dymond Precious Guilford ended in a 3-3 deadlock, but Kajal clinched it on criteria, securing India's third gold medal of the tournament. India added two silver medals in the 53kg and 57kg weight divisions. In the 53kg final, Antim Panghal conceded against Sweden's Emma Jonna Denise Malmgren due to an injury while in the 57kg category, Neha Sharma lost to China's Kexin Hong 4-0. In the 53kg division Nishu claimed a hard-fought bronze medal after besting Romania's Andrea Beatrice Ana on criteria (VPOI) after the bout ended in a 2-2 tie. India has accumulated 12 medals at the tournament – three gold, four silver, and five bronze. The focus now shifts to the Greco-Roman contests.



Kerr made his 'Project 222' a reality on Saturday. AP

shaving almost three seconds off his own personal best in the process. The 28-year-old Briton, roared on by a capacity 60,000 crowd at the London Diamond League meeting, ran a time of three minutes 42.66 seconds to break Hicham El Guerrouj's long-standing mark by 0.47 seconds. As part of 'Project 222', Kerr had targeted a sub-223-second race, and with Saturday's run he became the seventh Briton to hold the mile record and first since Steve Cram in 1985.

The results (winners only):
Men: 100m: Kanyinsola Ajayi, 9.84s; **400m:** Rai Benjamin, 44.05; **800m:** Brandon Miller, 1:42.19; **Mile:** Josh Kerr, 3:42.66 (WR); **110m hurdles:** Ja'Kobe Tharp, 12.89; **400mH:** Karsten Warholm, 46.61; **Pole vault:** Sam Kendricks 5.95m.

Women: 200m: Julien Alfred, 21.66s; **400m:** Marileidy Paulino 48.97; **800m:** Keely Hodgkinson 1:56.21; **3000m:** Jessica Hull 8:24.69; **High jump:** Nicola Olislagers 2.01m; **Long jump:** Malaika Mihambo 7.05.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA u-19 round robin tournament, Group-A: City-I vs City-II (Stag); Districts-III vs Districts-IV (Venkateswara); Group-B: Districts-I vs Districts-II (Pbel); City-III vs City-IV (Wahe Guru-A), 9 a.m. Tagore Sports-TNCA City Schools U-16 C. Ramaswamy Trophy (semifinal), St. Bede's-A vs Heartfulness International School NIOS-B (Gojan-C); Heartfulness International School NIOS-A vs PSBB (Nungambakkam), Tagore, 9 a.m.

AROUND THE CITY



All smiles: SRM IST defeated Prist University 40-29 to clinch the 62nd South India men's kabaddi tournament organised by Kulathur Kamarajar Sports Academy held at Kulathur.



One for the album: Rohit, left, and Lakshmi, right, the men's and women's champions of the RWD TNTA Tamil Nadu inter-collegiate tennis championships. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The best: The victorious SRM women's basketball team. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Rohit and Lakshmi win
A. Lakshmi Prabha of SRM University defeated fellow SRM student V. Sree Syleshwari 6-2, 6-1, in the women's final of the RWD TNTA Tamil Nadu inter-collegiate tennis championships at the SDAT tennis stadium in Nungambakkam.

Other results: Men: Final: Rohit Hari Balaji (Loyola) bt C. Thirumurugan (SRM) 5-4 (conceded). **Overall champion: Men:** Loyola (46 points); **Women:** SRM University (78).

SRM IST triumphs
SRM IST clinched the Sree

Raghavendra Basketball Club State-level inter-collegiate women's basketball tournament title.

Swagata scalps six
Off-spinner D. Swagata's six for 24 helped set up a six-wicket win for Red Rangers against Silver Strikers in the TNCA Freyer Cup women's one-day league tournament on Sunday. **The scores:** Yellow Challengers



D. Swagata (Red Rangers, 6/24)

167/9 in 41 overs (S. Nandhana 42) lost to Blue Avengers 168/8 in 40 overs (S. Gowri Lakshmi 50, S. Anupriya 31/17). Green Invaders 229/8 in 50 overs (K. Aasitha 34, S.R. Srisuvedha 85, Aparna Mondal 31 rtd. hurt) lost to Navy Knights 230/7 in 43.2 overs (G. Kamalini 66, M. Keerthika 53). Silver Strikers 158 in 43 overs (Sweta 57, D. Swagata 6/24) lost to Red Rangers 159/4 in 33.4 overs (N.S. Subhaharini 64 n.o.). Purple Blazers 256/6 in 50 overs (B. Sandhya 40, Arshi Choudhary 64, S. Vaishnavi 49) bt Maroon Mavericks 161 in 46.3 overs (Elokshi Arun 49, K.M. Sivapriya 49). **On Saturday:** Pink Warriors 154/7 in 45 overs (M. Anurakini 60

n.o.) bt Blue Avengers 143 in 42.3 overs (P. Janlin Chandra 3/28, V. Abirami 3/26). *Match reduced to 45 overs a side due to overnight rain.* Yellow Challengers 112 in 45.2 overs (P. Hansika 39, K. Aasitha 3/19) lost to Green Invaders 113/3 in 25.2 overs. Purple Blazers 130/7 in 33 overs (S. Vaishnavi 43) lost to Red Rangers 131/1 in 28.4 overs (N.S. Subhaharini 56 n.o.). *Match reduced to 33 overs per side due to overnight rain.* Silver Strikers 196/7 in 48 overs (D. Hemalatha 77 n.o.) lost to Orange Dragons 92/1 in 20.5 overs (S.G. Shrinishri 51 n.o.). *Orange Dragons won by 31 runs (VJD Method); Match reduced to 48 overs a side.*

Duke Of Tuscany obliges in Governor's Cup

BENGALURU: P. Shroff-trained Duke Of Tuscany (G. Vivek up) won the Governor's Cup (2,400m), the chief event of the races here on Sunday (July 19). The winner is owned by Five Stars Shipping Co. Pvt. Ltd. rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Rama Seshu Eyunni & Miss. Anita J. Captain. Jockey Antony won three races on the day.

THE RESULTS: KARNATAKA POLICE TROPHY (1,400M): ASHWA NEW YORK (Darshan) 1, Jolie's Star (G. Vivek) 2, Gifted Falcon (S. Shareef) 3 and Queendom (Trevor) 4. 1/2, 2-1/2 and 2. Im, 28.10s. ₹48 (w), 11, 18 and 50 (p), SHP: 60, FP: 369, Q: 275, Trinella: 11,721/7,534, Exacta: 50,261 (c/o)/5,385. Favourite: Regal Beauty. Owner: Mr. Ravinder Pal Singh Chauhan. Trainer: S. Narredu.

BOLD GESTURE PLATE (DIV. I), 1,200M: HONEYPOT (M. Rajesh K) 1, Jailer (Asirvatham) 2, Khazana (Aleemuddin) 3 and Legendary Impact (Vishal) 4. 7, 2-1/2 and 6. Im, 15.07s. ₹46 (w), 10, 13 and 12 (p), SHP: 29, THP: 33, FP: 165, Q: 77, Trinella: 279/117, Exacta: 96/7

459. Favourite: Jailer. Owner: Mr. Reethan B.K. Trainer: V. Narayana Gowda.

1. AMAZING GRACE PLATE (DIV. II), 1,400M: SLING SHOT (G. Vivek) 1, Embosom (Vaibhav) 2, Infinite Spirit (Pavan) 3 and Sea God (Arul) 4. Not run: N R I Millennium. 3-1/2, 3-1/2 and 2. Im, 30.58s. ₹22 (w), 11, 14 and 17 (p), SHP: 66, THP: 35, FP: 186, Q: 203, Trinella: 652/188, Exacta: 7,260, 1356. Favourite: Sling Shot. Owner: Mr. H.R. Pai. Trainer: Praveen Jesu.

2. MAMMA'S MINK PLATE (1,200M): EMINENT GOLD (Antony) 1, Teak (G. Vivek) 2, Personal Legend (A. Asbar) 3 and Sai Princess (Jagadeesh) 4. Lnk, Hd and 2-1/2. Im, 15.38s. ₹74 (w), 19, 14 and 13 (p), SHP: 39, THP: 50, FP: 431, Q: 246, Trinella: 1,985/709, Exacta: 5,206/2,677. Favourite: Perfect Dream. Owners: Mr. Mukul A. Sonawala, The Estate of Late R.R. Byramji & Mr. Chetan Shantilal Shah. Trainer: Darius Byramji.

3. AMAZING GRACE PLATE (DIV. I), 1,400M: LEX LUTHER (Antony) 1, Double Scotch (I. Chisty) 2, Fria (Lave Kumar) 3 and Peridot (Siddharaju P) 4. Not run: Princess Jas-

mine. 1/2, 3-1/2 and 1-1/4. Im, 29.98s. ₹29 (w), 12, 10 and 28 (p), SHP: 29, THP: 67, FP: 71, Q: 33, Trinella: 711/536, Exacta: 4,828/1,128. Favourite: Double Scotch. Owner: Mr. Srinivasa M. Trainer: Kishan Thomas.

4. RAJA OF BOBBILI MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,400M): AQUAMATIC (Akshay K) 1, Invincible (Kiran Rai) 2, Star Comet (Vinod Shinde) 3 and Absolute Force (Trevor) 4. 1-1/2, 1 and 2-1/2. Im, 27.47s. ₹35 (w), 12, 16 and 21 (p), SHP: 52, THP: 41, FP: 666, Q: 403, Trinella: 3,115/1,335, Exacta: 4,473/1,109. Favourite: Absolute Force. Owners: Mr. Praveen Kumar N & Mr. Naveen Preben Gowda. Trainer: Azhar Ali.

5. GOVERNOR'S CUP (2,400M): DUKE OF TUSCANY (G. Vivek) 1, Victor Hugo (Akshay K) 2, Moon Star (Vinod Shinde) 3 and Queen Of Kings (Neeraj) 4. 3-1/4, 1-1/2 and 6. 2m, 33.44s. ₹12 (w), 10 and 12 (p), SHP: 13, THP: 18, FP: 14, Q: 15, Trinella: 27/16, Exacta: -. Favourite: Duke Of Tuscany. Owners: Five Stars Shipping Co. Pvt. Ltd. rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Rama Seshu Eyunni & Miss.

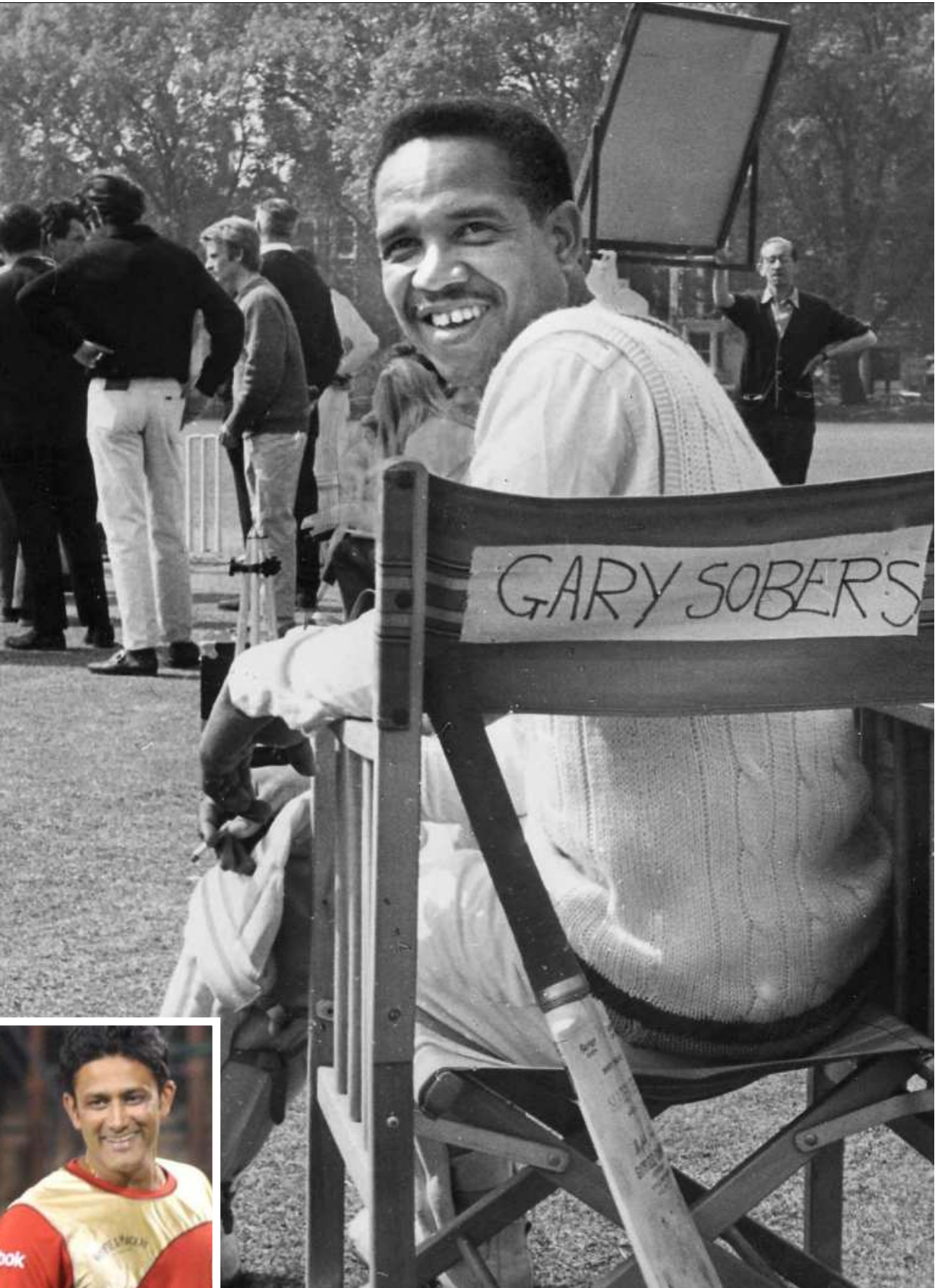
Anita J. Captain. Trainer: P. Shroff.

6. FLIRTING VISION PLATE (DIV. II), 1,200M: DONCASTER BELLE (Antony) 1, Rocking Star (R. Pradeep) 2, Preview (Suraj) 3 and The One And Only (Akshay K) 4. 1-1/4, 3-1/2 and 1-1/2. Im, 15.20s. ₹43 (w), 15, 11 and 10 (p), SHP: 26, THP: 63, FP: 142, Q: 66, Trinella: 309/79, Exacta: 1,757/1,464. Favourite: Preview. Owners: Mr. S.R. Sanas, Manjri Horse Breed's Farm Pvt Ltd, Mr. Aditya P Thackersey, Mr. Ashok Ranpise & M/s. DT Racing & Breeding LLP. Trainer: Darius Byramji.

7. FLIRTING VISION PLATE (DIV. I), 1,200M: VIBRANT QUEEN (A. Hangal) 1, Carat Love (Neeraj) 2, Deep Respect (Suraj) 3 and Makoto (Siddharaju P) 4. 3-1/4, 3 and 1. Im, 14.27s. ₹42 (w), 15, 11 and 11 (p), SHP: 37, THP: 68, FP: 424, Q: 159, Trinella: 351/107, Exacta: 4,173/8,049. Favourite: Deep Respect. Owner: Mr. V. Shankar. Trainer: Pradeep Annaiah.

Jackpot: ₹3,663; Runner-up: 248; Mini Jackpot: 1,173; Treble (0): 2,360; (0): 253.





Cricket’s Greatest — a legacy beyond numbers

The unchecked outpouring of grief at his passing, followed almost immediately by tales of his kindness and generosity, are testament to the standing Sir Garfield Sobers enjoys in the cricketing ecosystem in which he is the unquestioned emperor

R. Kaushik

The legacy a celebrated, high-profile achiever leaves behind isn’t defined merely by awards and accomplishments, no matter how staggeringly impressive they might be, but equally — if not more — by how many people they have touched, how many lives they have impacted, how much joy they have provided.

The unchecked outpouring of grief at his passing, followed almost immediately by tales of his kindness and generosity, are testament to the standing Sir Garfield Sobers enjoys in the cricketing ecosystem, of which he was the unquestioned emperor for the longest of times, and beyond. Sobers was ‘the greatest’ long before hyperbole took root and even the commonplace was labelled ‘great’. He was cricket’s Muhammad Ali. Scratch that. Ali was boxing’s Sobers, if that makes sense, given that the Sobers aura had pervaded the sporting world long before Cassius Clay became Muhammad Ali, and floated like a butterfly and stung like a bee.

In the three days since Sobers shuffled off the Shakespearian mortal coil, the tributes have come thick and fast, from those who played with and against him, from those who were fortunate enough to be the recipients of his wisdom and goodness, and from those who have heard of his exploits from others and have had to reconcile to watching his genius on *YouTube*. That he was universally adored was obvious long before he left us for what is certain to be a better world

Farokh Engineer, the maverick wicketkeeper-batter, and Bishan Bedi, the late former skipper, were among the earliest to be blessed by the charm of Sobers, given that both were regulars in the English county circuit

merely because he is inhabiting it. His demise has rekindled old memories and enveloped his peers and juniors in a sea of nostalgia, which remains the overwhelming theme that has accompanied any mention of Sir Garry since Friday night (IST).

Sobers’ international career spanned 20 years, his first-class stint 22; he didn’t play competitively after July 1974. But even 52 years on, the stirring deeds

are spoken about with awe and reverence. In his final representative outing, for his beloved Nottinghamshire against Worcestershire, he unleashed 84 in an 18-run loss at Worcester in the quarterfinals of the Gillette Cup 60-over domestic tournament in England.

It was his 95th List-A match, of which only one, against England in September 1973, was an international fixture. The legend was dismissed without scoring, caught behind off by Chris Old, as West Indies went down by one wicket in a low-scoring thriller.

Imagine that — Garry Sobers, Test average 57.78, 8,032 runs, 26 centuries and a highest of 365 not out, averages 0 in ODIs. Oh, the wicked humour of the one above us. On the face of it, given his exceptional versatility and the multiple skillsets that allowed him to dominate the longer version as a bowler alone or as a batter alone — not to mention his terrific fielding or his sensational catching which netted him 109 grabs in 93 Tests, mostly close in — Sobers ought to have been a natural fit in limited-overs cricket.

He didn’t reproduce his lofty First Class deeds in the shorter format (there was obviously no 20-over games in his playing days) but no one is really complaining because his one-day career ended nearly a year before the first of three Prudential World Cup (60 overs a side) was staged in



THE HINDU ARCHIVES, GETTY IMAGES & K. BHAGYA PRAKASH

England in the summer of 1975.

Sobers and India had a strong bond shaped by mutual respect and love and respect. Farokh Engineer, that maverick wicketkeeper-batter, and Bishan Bedi, the late former skipper, were among the earliest to be blessed by the charm of Sobers, given that both were regulars in the English county circuit and often encountered Sobers’ genius from close quarters with admiration but also, one senses, a tinge of trepidation. But among his greatest ‘fans’, if one might use that word, are the two little masters who were the combined backbone of the Indian batting for nearly a dozen years, each bringing his own unique style and together producing the kind of magic that mesmerised the best, Sobers included.

Sunil Gavaskar first played internationally 55 years back, as a 21-year-old, making his debut in the Caribbean in March 1971. By then, G.R. Vishwanath had already announced himself on the international stage, with a hundred in his first Test, against Australia in Kanpur a year and a half previously. Like his future brother-in-law, ‘Vishy’ was also on his first overseas tour when Ajit Wadekar led his troops out to the Caribbean islands in 1971, little aware that the Indians were walking into history.

Almost from their first meeting, Sobers and the other great West Indian batter of that time, Rohan Kanhai, took a shine to the technician from Bombay and the magician from Bangalore. With the charismatic M.L. Jaisimha helping break the ice in his inimitable fashion — the debonair Hyderabad and the proud Barbadian shared a wonderful bond — the two young men benefitted from the voluntary advice even during Test matches of Sobers and Kanhai. At least one of them has spoken of a gentle ‘warning’ from the slip cordon after a false stroke. ‘Don’t throw it away, you have done all the hard work. Focus. Concentrate.’ Can you imagine that? A superstar of the game, the opposition captain, no less, looking out for you in an unequal battle of two versus 11. How could they not become Sobers converts? How could they not indeed?

In his 2022 autobiography *Wrist Assured*, Vishwanath writes, “Sir Garry is easily the greatest cricketer I have played

with and against, no two ways about it. At various stages during that tour, I had to pinch myself as a reminder that I wasn’t actually dreaming of being on the same ground as him.”

That tour in 1971 was a seminal one in Indian cricket history. India didn’t have the greatest overseas record at the time. But fuelled by the brilliance of Gavaskar, whose debut series fetched him a massive 774 runs in four Tests, the dependability of Dilip Sardesai as well as the three-pronged spin attack of Bedi, E.A.S. Prasanna and S. Venkataraghavan, superbly complemented by that affable maverick Salim Durrani, India registered a 1-0 triumph, their first series victory in the Caribbean. That was the catalyst for a similar scoreline in England a few months later when the mystery-propelled leg-spin of B.S. Chandrasekhar sparked a grand victory at The Oval.

In the West Indies, India had the temerity to enforce the follow-on for the first time against their hosts in the first Test in Kingston, where Sobers had conjured an unbeaten 365, the highest individual score in Test cricket for 36 years, in 1958. The first day’s play was washed out, and after India bowled West Indies out for 217 in response to their 387 around tea on day four, Wadekar darted over to the West Indian dressing room to inform Sobers that they would have to bat again.

“I hope you are only joking,” Sobers laughed, only to be met by a neutral, “No, not joking,” from the Indian skipper, who explained that since it was now a four-day Test, a lead of 150 was enough to stick the opposition back in. “All right maan, so we will bat again.” “Ajit had fired an unexpected salvo,” Vishwanath recalls in the book. “We feared retaliation of some sort and sure enough, Rohan and Sir Garry, did not disappoint. Almost as if they were slighted at being asked to bat again, the two virtuosos put on an exhibition on the last day.

Vantage position

“Later in that series, at the Kensington Oval in Barbados where the square boundaries aren’t too long, I was stationed at deep square-leg for the sweep with Pras bowling to him. From my vantage position, I had a fantastic, uninterrupted view of Sir Garry. He

Sobers had a kind word and a smile not just for his fellow cricketers. On the rest day (yes, it was a thing once upon a time) of the Pongal Test in Madras in 1967, he was gracious enough to interact with several kids

shaped to come forward. saw the trajectory was short, and quickly rocked on to the back foot. He didn’t play the pull, more a whip with the blade more vertical than horizontal. Oh, the horror... The ball crashed into the wall and ricocheted halfway back into the ground. It was a ferocious stroke played all along the ground, the control immaculate. I quickly did my mathematics; he was 34, had played international cricket for 16 years. I couldn’t start to imagine what he would have been like at his peak.”

Sobers had a kind word and a smile not just for his fellow cricketers, he also loved interacting with kids. On the rest day (yes, it was a thing once upon a time) of the Pongal Test in Madras in January 1967, despite being unbeaten on 95 at the end of the third day, Sobers was gracious enough to interact with several kids, some of whom had made the trip from Bangalore with their parents to watch the match, and fine-tune their games to the extent that it can be done in one short stint. He wasn’t expected to do anything of that sort, it was not an obligation or a social media gimmick or a sponsor commitment. It’s just something that came naturally to him, and while he might not have thought a great deal about it, it left the teenaged lads with memories for a lifetime. In the long list of people that he has touched, these kids too figure, prominently. Sobers never went out of his way to win friends and influence people; he didn’t have to, you see.

Endearing video

There is an endearing video of Anura Tennekoon, the former Sri Lankan captain who is now a young 79, interacting with the 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi during the triangular ‘A’ series in Sri Lanka last month. Tennekoon made the 161-kilometre drive from Colombo to Dambulla merely to offer the young man words of advice and encouragement.

Sobers was like that too, turning up mainly at Bridgetown to catch up with young batters who fired his imagination, batters like Sachin Tendulkar and Rahul Dravid and Virat Kohli. He was a giver in the truest sense. He gave the bowlers great grief though he did so with such class and elegance that they almost didn’t seem to mind. He gave his teammates, the connoisseurs and the fans the ultimate joy. He gave West Indian cricket, at the time divided by regional considerations, a sense of pride and identity. The Big Man upstairs broke the mould after he made Sir Garfield Sobers, the original Champion of Champions.



THE GIST

▼ Sobers’ international career spanned 20 years, his First Class stint 22; he didn’t play competitively after July 1974. But even 52 years on, the stirring deeds are spoken about with awe and reverence

▼ His exceptional versatility and multiple skillsets allowed him to dominate the longer version as a bowler alone or as a batter alone. Sobers ought to have been a natural fit in limited-overs cricket

▼ Though he gave the bowlers great grief, he did so with such class and elegance that they almost didn’t seem to mind. He gave his teammates, the connoisseurs and fans the ultimate joy. He gave West Indian cricket a sense of pride and identity

The materials and methods that made the Vikram-1 launch unique

If its engine is printed, the airframe is woven: carbon-fibre composite — filaments of near-pure carbon set in resin — offers strength per unit weight many times that of aerospace aluminium or maraging steel; Skyroot has thus claimed a five-fold saving over the best rocket steel

Jacob Koshy

The Vikram-1 rocket, built by the Hyderabad firm Skyroot, shot through the sky a little past noon on July 18. The seven-storey-tall vehicle lifted off ISRO's First Launch Pad at Sriharikota and, a little over 15 minutes later, placed its payloads in an orbit roughly 450 km above the earth. The mission, named 'Aagaman', Sanskrit for 'arrival', made India only the third country, after the U.S. and China, whose private industry can reach orbit on its own launch vehicle.

Rocket engines have traditionally been forged, machined, welded from dozens of parts. 3D printing inverts this. A laser fuses metal powder layer upon layer, building the part up from nothing. There are some real advantages to this approach. An engine printed as one piece sheds the bolts, seals, and joints where conventional engines leak and fail. When Skyroot test-fired its 'Raman' engine in 2020, it said the fully printed injector halved the mass and cut components and lead time by 80% against conventional manufacturing.

Complex internal plumbing — the fine cooling channels that let Vikram-1's regeneratively cooled engine chill itself with its own propellant — can be printed in shapes no drill can reach. Prototypes emerge in days, not months, so a startup can test, fail, and redesign at a pace that would have been anathema to ISRO's supply chains. The downsides are more subtle: peer-reviewed surveys of the field flag porosity, rough internal surfaces, and batch-to-batch variability, and NASA has documented a printed copper combustion chamber failing on the test stand from degraded material quality.

A printed engine, in short, is faster and lighter but demands obsessive quality control. The flaws hide inside the layers.

Carbon-composite body

If the engine is printed, the airframe is woven. Carbon-fibre composite — filaments of near-pure carbon set in resin — offers strength per unit weight many times that of aerospace aluminium or maraging steel. Skyroot claims a five-fold saving over the best rocket steel. Every kilogram of structure trimmed is a kilogram of satellite gained.

The American company Rocket Lab's Electron rocket pioneered the approach. The material also resists fatigue and corrosion and can be laid up by automated machines into seamless tubes. Vikram-1's own stage-1 is India's longest single-piece composite rocket stage. However, the material and its curing infrastructure are expensive; its strength runs along the fibres, so a poorly designed laminate is strong one way and brittle another; and damage can lurk



This photograph taken on July 7, 2026 shows a Vikram-S rocket model at Skyroot Aerospace facility on the outskirts of Hyderabad. AFP

beneath a perfect surface, demanding ultrasonic inspection where a dent in aluminium announces itself.

Both Vikram-1 and PSLV are four-stage expendable rockets that end in a restartable liquid stage for precise orbital insertion: Vikram-1's Orbital Adjustment Module is a miniature cousin of the PSLV's PS4. Both lean on India's long mastery of solid propulsion. However, the PSLV is a 44-metre, 320-tonne workhorse alternating solid and liquid stages to lift 1,750 kg to polar orbit. Vikram-1 is a 22-metre featherweight stacking three solid stages under its liquid module to carry 350 kg.

The nearer analogue is the SSLV. Both Vikram-1 and the SSLV have three solid-fuel stages capped by a small restartable liquid module, both conceived for small satellites on short notice.

On raw capacity, ISRO wins: SSLV lifts 500 kg to low-earth orbit against Vikram-1's 350 kg. However Vikram's all-carbon airframe is leaner than SSLV's conventional casings. Most of all, SSLV was designed by the state and its production licensed to Hindustan Aeronautics Limited for ₹511 crore; Vikram-1 is owned outright by its maker, financed by venture capital, and priced by the market.

First flight

According to reports, the Vikram-1 developmental flight met almost every one of its checkpoints, including the process called 'long coast', a tricky phase for a debutant, where the rocket must

For a maiden flight whose stated ambition was merely to clear the tower and gather data, reaching orbit is an important achievement: Electron, Firefly's Alpha, and ISRO's own SSLV all stumbled the first time

hold its attitude with nothing pushing it while the printed engine burns one last time. For a maiden flight whose stated ambition was merely to clear the tower and gather data, reaching orbit is an important achievement: Electron, Firefly's Alpha, and ISRO's own SSLV all stumbled the first time.

The rocket carried five working payloads and two talismans: EMBRACE, a robotic-arm demonstration by CosmoServe Space aimed at grabbing space debris; the SOLARAS satellite from Grahaa Space; Skyroot's own SCOPE experimental satellite; and two deployable-technology demonstrators, uD3PP and mD3RN, from the German firm Dcubed.

Alongside flew a lab-grown diamond lotus and an 18-karat gold micro-rocket bearing rice-grain sculptures of 'Sarabhai', 'Raman', and 'Kalam' — the three names Skyroot gives its rockets and engines. The company has said that all the payloads have been deployed.

Building rockets

Skyroot holds both of Indian private

spaceflight's firsts — the suborbital Vikram-S launch in November 2022 and now an orbital launch with customer payloads.

But Chennai's AgniKul Cosmos, incubated at IIT-Madras, is running a parallel course. Its Agnibaan SORTeD vehicle flew a suborbital flight in May 2024 from India's first private launchpad, on the world's first single-piece 3D-printed engine — a semi-cryogenic design burning liquid oxygen and kerosene, a propellant technology ISRO itself is still maturing.

Having test-fired four Agnilet engines in cluster this May, and with former ISRO chairman S. Somanath joining its board, AgniKul is working on its Mission 02: a two-stage Agnibaan attempting India's first sea recovery of an orbital-class booster while the rocket's upper stage reaches orbit as a working platform. Mission 02, in other words, aims at reusability — the technology that rewrote launch economics and the next barrier Indian rockets must clear.

Since the 2020 reforms and IN-SPACE's creation in 2022, India's space startups have multiplied from a handful to more than 400, but until Saturday (July 18) they all needed ISRO's rockets to fly. A private launcher now could turn ISRO from gatekeeper into landlord — and turn access to orbit from a national programme into a market. The small-satellite launch business is supply-starved worldwide; Skyroot pitches itself as a "cab service" to space. *jacob.koshy@thehindu.co.in*

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



Egyptian workers load bails of plastic for recycling on a truck at the garbage city in the Manshiyet Nasser neighbourhood, Cairo, on July 6. Hundreds of recyclers and manufacturers across Egypt are benefiting from a war-driven surge in demand ever since the U.S. and Iran choked off the Strait of Hormuz, a major shipping lane for the raw materials from which plastic is made. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Finning: cruel, wasteful practice

Agence France Presse

Finning, the practice of removing a shark's fins and casting the rest of the shark overboard, often alive. The animal will subsequently drown. Finning is largely prohibited across a variety of regulatory zones, countries and international conventions, even if fishing certain shark species is generally allowed.

Yet in recent years, illegal shark fins have been repeatedly landed in Senegal's capital Dakar, one of Africa's busiest fishing ports, by dozens of Chinese and Taiwanese longline tuna vessels, according to a report released last week by the London-based Environmental Justice Foundation NGO.

The fins are then shipped to Asia for use in shark fin soup, a delicacy in certain countries, or in traditional medicine.

The practice is inherently cruel and wasteful, conservationists say, likening it to killing a rhinoceros for its horn. But brutality is not the only problem.

Global shark populations have been in rapid decline due to industrial fishing, with a study published in the journal Nature showing their population has plummeted, alongside that of their close relatives rays, 71% since 1970.

Finning also often occurs in tandem with other types of illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing and human



A picture taken on November 17, 2022, shows shark fins laid out on a tarp outside a shop in Hong Kong. AFP

rights abuses.

Senegal is a party to the International Commission for the Conservation of Atlantic Tunas, which regulates fishing operations related to tuna and tuna-like species in the Atlantic Ocean. It also bans the retention of certain species of sharks and specifies that fins cannot total more than 5% of the overall weight of sharks onboard. The rule is meant to prevent finning, but makes things difficult to quantify.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people killed by Israel in Gaza since Oct. 2025 truce

1,144 Gaza's civil defence and hospitals said Israeli attacks on Saturday killed 11 people across the territory. A ceasefire remains in place between Israel and the Hamas, but it has not halted the violence in Gaza. At least 1,144 Palestinians had been killed since the truce took effect last October, according to Gaza's Health Ministry. AFP

Amount of old age pension released by Punjab government

1423 in ₹ crores. The Punjab government has released ₹1,423.33 crore under the old-age pension scheme so far in the current financial year, Social Security, Women and Child Development Minister Baljit Kaur said on Sunday. She said around 23.77 lakh senior citizens across the State are receiving financial assistance under the scheme. PTI

Decrease in transit trade between Afghanistan-Pakistan

367 in \$ million. Afghanistan-Pakistan transit trade plunged to \$367 million in the outgoing fiscal year from \$5 billion in 2021, according to a media report. The transit trade between the two countries has suffered one of its steepest declines, plummeting to just 11,592 containers in FY-26, the Dawn reported on Sunday. PTI

Patients who availed free cardiac treatment in Punjab

135 According to Punjab's State Health Agency, the beneficiaries underwent treatment for congenital heart defects, valve disorders and other complex cardiac conditions under the scheme. The government said young adults in the 17-35 age group accounted for the highest number of beneficiaries receiving cashless cardiac procedures. PTI

Number of deaths in U.P. due to human-animal conflict

4000 Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday called for raising awareness on human-animal conflict and also pressed the need for leveraging technology to minimise the loss of lives. He also said that over 4,000 people have lost their lives in human-animal conflict. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On the second phase of U.S.-Iran war

The second phase of the Iran-U.S. war is primarily centred on the future of the Strait of Hormuz. The MoU stipulated that Iran would allow 60 days of free passage for ships through the strait and define its future administration with Oman. Subsequent talks in Doha broke down over U.S. resistance to a formal management plan

EXPLAINER

M. Kalyanaraman

The second phase of the Iran-U.S. war is being fought almost exclusively over the future of the Strait of Hormuz. The sequence of events leading to the restart of hostilities suggests there was no genuine meeting of minds when the MoU was signed. As before, by holding out and retaliating, Iran has forced the issue – shipowners now seem resigned to paying a “logical” toll, even as they worry about the precedent it sets for other straits.

Events that led to the war

The two countries agreed to a ceasefire on June 14 and the terms of the MoU were finalised, which stipulated that Iran would allow ships to pass “with no charge for 60 days only,” and that Iran would work with Oman to “define the future administration and maritime services” in the strait. Two days later, the Persian Gulf Strait Authority – set up by Iran in May to handle transits – circulated terms reasserting itself as the nodal transit authority, requiring every vessel to hold a passage permit and PGSA-approved insurance, free for now but with fees reserved for later. Iran was formalising its stake as a legal outcome of the MoU.

U.S. and Iranian delegations met in Switzerland on June 21, and sanctions were lifted the next day. But the PGSA, already sanctioned, was never explicitly relieved – leaving shipping firms wary of dealing with it.

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio then toured the UAE, Kuwait and Bahrain from June 23-25, culminating in a Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) meeting in Bahrain. Amid that visit, on June 24, the International Maritime Organization (IMO) – working with Oman – formally announced a temporary corridor: a southern one via Oman, alongside the northern route Iran championed. This effectively formalised the Omani route.



The second phase of the war is fought almost exclusively over the future of the Strait of Hormuz. REUTERS

Iran complained it had not been consulted and said any other route barring the route it had specified was “unauthorised and dangerous.”

The next day in Bahrain, Mr. Rubio said accepting a toll near a country's territorial waters “will spread throughout the world like a contagion,” adding that no Gulf state supported one. The U.S. and GCC signed a statement opposing Iran's control of the strait. Iran did not take this quietly. The IRGC threatened vessels on non-Iranian routes, and the IMO's governing council “strongly condemned” Iran's bid to “establish an entity purporting to control traffic through the strait.”

On June 30, U.S. and Iranian officials met in Doha. Reports said Iran and Oman had floated a plan to monetise transits – a voluntary toll modelled on the Malacca-Singapore Straits – which Washington rejected in favour of the pre-war status quo.

A Maritime and Port Authority of Singapore spokesperson, responding exclusively to *The Hindu*, said the Straits of Malacca and Singapore are, like

Hormuz, Straits Used for International Navigation, and that Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore accordingly levy no fees or tolls on ships exercising transit passage. A voluntary Aids to Navigation Fund exists, backed by contributors including The Nippon Foundation, but the spokesperson stressed its “contributions are not for the exercise of transit passage and should not be misconstrued as fees, tolls or payment imposed on transiting ships.” Talks in Doha broke down over U.S. resistance to any formal management arrangement – effectively a bid to walk back the MoU's own Hormuz clauses.

Hostilities resume

The first week of July brought the mourning period for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. As the NATO summit opened in Turkey on July 7 – where U.S. officials restated their Hormuz position, and Donald Trump complained European allies weren't helping keep the strait free for navigation – Iran struck three ships on the Omani route, among them the India-bound Al Rekayyat, one of the largest LNG carriers built. An exploding

LNG tanker at a chokepoint ranks among shipping's worst-case scenarios. Mr. Trump declared the ceasefire over. War had resumed.

On July 11, 2026, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi met with Omani Foreign Minister Badr Albusaidi in Muscat to discuss the strait but the meeting apparently produced no agreement. A few hours later, Iran attacked the DFS Galaxy, in which one Indian seafarer died, bringing the recent Iranian attacks on ships to six. The U.S. began attacking merchant ships too, as part of its blockade against Iranian oil trade. It has reinstated the sanctions it had briefly lifted.

Washington keeps claiming it has degraded Iran's capacity to strike shipping – a claim repeated after nearly every strike, rebutted each time by a fresh attack. For instance, on July 13, CENTCOM said strikes on six Iranian sites would “further degrade” that capability; the IRGC responded the same day by claiming it had disabled two tankers.

Strikes on Greater Tunb Island on July 15 drew the same claim. Yet on July 16, the Joint Maritime Information Center raised its Hormuz risk rating to “severe,” and nine Greek-operated LNG tankers stayed put rather than risk transit – insurers, the most reliable independent judges, are pricing in continued Iranian capability. Lloyd's List data shows weekly transits that nearly doubled to 282 for June 22-28 have since fallen to 164 for July 6-12, concentrated on the Omani route.

Iran has now turned to alternatives to the strait – targeting ship-to-ship transfers off UAE's Fujairah pipeline and pushing the Houthis to shut off Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline route by attacking ships taking the Red Sea route.

“Shipping companies are super tired [of] all this back and forth,” said Dimitris Maniatis, CEO of Greek maritime risk firm Marisks, at a Lloyd's List webinar. “Most would accept a toll amount that is logical, not 20% though which is ludicrous. If a legitimate arrangement is formulated, shippers would welcome the development.”

THE GIST

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What is the legal tussle surrounding the Taj Mahal?

What controversial claims have been made about the monument over the years?

Ziya Us Salam

The story so far

Taj Mahal, the seventeenth-century tomb, is once again in the news. Earlier this month, the Allahabad High Court issued notices to the Centre and the Archaeological Survey of India, asking for their response to a plea challenging an Agra trial court order refusing a survey of the Taj Mahal. A Bench of Justice Rohit Ranjan Agarwal passed the order on a petition filed by advocate Harishankar Jain contending that the Taj, a UNESCO World Heritage monument, is actually ‘Tejo Mahalaya’.

Mr. Jain pleaded for a declaration that the Taj Mahal is a Hindu temple and sought permission for Hindus to offer prayers there. The petitioners also sought the appointment of an Advocate Commissioner to inspect the monument. Built by Mughal emperor Shah Jahan as

a tomb for his favourite wife Arjumand Bano, the Taj Mahal took 22 years to be completed. Constructed under chief architect Ustad Ahmed Lahori, the first time it faced a controversy was when it was claimed by many in the West that the architect of the Taj was Venetian Geronimo Veroneo, a jeweller by profession. That was in the 17th Century. Then came the claim by Mughal Beg in Tarikh-e-Taj Mahal that the Taj was designed by Muhammad Effendi, an architect supposedly sent by the Sultan of Turkey. Effendi, however, was not an architect as subsequent revelations proved.

What was P.N. Oak's claim?

Then in the mid-19th Century, it was claimed that the monument was the result of the genius of Frenchman Austin de Bordeaux, a jeweller by profession. However, Austin died in 1632, the year the work on the Taj began.

No historian of medieval India has contested the fact of the Taj being a tomb of the Mughal emperor Shah Jahan's wife. This includes the illustrious historians Irfan Habib and Athar Ali, besides noted names like Satish Chopra and Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi. The first person to cast aspersions on the tomb's authenticity was a non-historian, P.N. Oak, a teacher-turned-lawyer-turned-journalist, who, through his book *Taj Mahal is a Temple Palace*, claimed in 1965 that the Taj was originally a Rajput palace built in the 4th century. In 1989, Oak revised his opinion and claimed it was originally a Hindu temple built in the early 12th century. Again, he penned a book, *Taj Mahal: The True Story*, to buttress his contention. It was the first time anybody associated the monument with a Hindu deity. The historians rejected his claims as lacking credibility in the absence of any evidence. Oak's claim, however, was heard in the Supreme Court, which

rejected it outright in 2000.

What legal challenges followed?

In 2005, Amarnath Mishra, now a member of Ayodhya Sadbhavna Samiti, went to Allahabad High Court claiming the Taj was a temple built by the Chandela rulers in 1189. The court dismissed his contention too.

The opponents did not give up. In 2015, a civil suit filed at an Agra trial court sought to declare the Taj Mahal a Hindu temple. The court, however, didn't agree with the claim. After it refused to order a survey of the Taj premises, like the one ordered in Gyanvapi and Bhojshala, the petitioners went to Allahabad High Court. The court then sought response from the Union Government and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

What was the ASI's stand?

In 2017, the ASI stated unambiguously that the Taj was a 17th-century tomb. The technology used in its construction and design, including pietra dura, did not exist in pre-medieval days. It should have ended any vestiges of controversy. However, a PIL was filed by a BJP leader in the Supreme Court in 2022. It was dismissed too. Two years later, some activists tried to offer Gangajal at the Taj. That attempt, too, was foiled. Now, following the Allahabad HC ruling, the ball is in the Centre's court, besides the ASI yet again.

THE GIST

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Test your knowledge on the life and career of Sir Garfield Sobers who passed away recently

*The leader
trusted only
his sycophants*

In terms of grammar, both sentences are acceptable. When someone says he is a teacher of English, what he means is that teaching is his profession, and the subject he teaches is English - there is no ambiguity here. The second sentence - 'I'm an English teacher' - is frequently heard in our country, and it can be interpreted in two different ways. Like the first sentence, it could mean that the person is someone who teaches English. But 'English teacher' could also be interpreted to mean that the teacher's nationality is English - in other words, he is from England.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/indigence

International Phonetic Alphabet: /'ɪndɪʒəns/

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